

Eyes on the Ballot Watchers: The State of Civic Space for Citizen Election Observers in Africa

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ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

ACDEG:	African Charter on Democracy, Elections and Governance
ACFIM:	Alliance for Finance Monitoring
ACHPR:	African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights
AfEONet:	Africa Election Observers Network
AHEAD:	Action for Holistic Electoral Approach for Democracy
AU:	Africa Union
BOCONGO:	Botswana Council of Non-Governmental Organisations
CANGO:	Coordinating Assembly of NGOs
CENI:	Commission Électorale Nationale Indépendante
CFI:	Civic Forum Initiative
CIPESA:	Collaboration on International ICT Policy in East and Southern Africa
CODEO:	Coalition of Domestic Election Observers
CSOs:	Civil Society Organisations
ECG:	Ghana's Electoral Commission
ECOWAS:	Economic Community of West African States
E-HORN:	East and Horn of Africa Election Observers Network.
ELOG:	Elections Observation Group ELOG
EMBs:	Electoral Management Bodies
EPD:	European Partnership for Democracy
ERC:	Election Resource Centre
ESN-SA:	Electoral Support Network of Southern Africa
ICNL:	International Center for Not-for-Profit Law

IEBC: Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission

IFES: International Foundation for Electoral Systems

INEC: Independent National Electoral Commission

International IDEA: International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance

ISIE: Independent High Authority for Elections

NDI: National Democratic Institute

NGOs: Non-Governmental Organisations

PVO: Private Voluntary Organisations

SADC: Southern African Development Community

UNDP: United Nations Development Programme

WAEON: West Africa Election Observers Network

ZESN: Zimbabwe Election Support Network

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1. Introduction and Background

Democracy extends far beyond the act of voting, yet transparent, accountable, and credible elections remain a cornerstone of democratic governance. Domestic citizen election observers, often broad coalitions of civil society organizations, play a pivotal role in protecting electoral integrity before, during, and after polling. As defined by IDEA (1997)¹, election observation is the systematic collection and assessment of information against established laws and regulations. It promotes transparency, builds public confidence, deters malpractice, eases tensions, and enhances the credibility of electoral authorities. This near-universal democratic practice has become indispensable in safeguarding citizens' political rights.

Across Africa, Civil Society Organizations (CSOs), faith-based groups, professional associations, and grassroots movements have played critical roles in observing elections, documenting irregularities, and promoting transparency, especially in contexts where state institutions may lack independence or capacity. As such, citizen observers have emerged as frontline defenders of democracy, especially as authoritarian trends threaten civic space. Their localized knowledge of political, cultural, and linguistic contexts enables them to detect irregularities and report abuses that may elude international missions (Aniekwe & Atuobi, 2016).

Most African countries recognize citizen observation in their national electoral laws, often aligned with frameworks such as the African Charter on Democracy, Elections, and Governance (AU, 2007)² and the ECOWAS Protocol on Democracy and Good Governance (2001)³. That withstanding, their ability to operate varies widely. While Southern and Western Africa often offer more enabling environments, restrictive laws, bureaucratic hurdles, and political intimidation remain pervasive in North and Central Africa (Venice Commission, 2024; HRW, 2023).

¹ IDEA, 1997, 'Code of Conduct – Ethical and Professional Observation of Elections (https://aceproject.org/main/samples/po/pox_m027.en.pdf?utm)

² **Article 3 of the African Charter on Democracy, Elections and Governance (ACDEG)** commits AU member states to promote the establishment of conditions conducive to democratic participation including independent observation and monitoring by CSOs.

³ **Article 12 of the ECOWAS Protocol on Democracy and Good Governance** acknowledges the role of CSOs in election observation. **Article 13** reinforces the right of citizen observers to participate in electoral observation missions and mandates ECOWAS Member States to accredit and provide access to them.

The African Union, ECOWAS, and SADC have institutionalized election observation, but inconsistent methodologies, political interference, and lack of coordination undermine its impact (Bittiger, 2005).

Over the years, citizen observer groups in Africa have increasingly adopted data-driven approaches such as Parallel Vote Tabulation (PVT), digital reporting tools, and real-time analysis to generate credible, evidence-based assessments of electoral integrity. However, the operating space for observers is often constrained by restrictive legal frameworks, limited resources, and shrinking civic space (IDEA, 2021).

This report assesses the state of civic space for citizen observers in 21 African countries across eight dimensions, from legal frameworks to data access, identifying systemic barriers, regional disparities, and reform priorities essential for protecting this vital democratic function.

1.1 Study Rationale

Over the past four decades, one of the most important democratic gains in Africa has been the emergence of independent, non-partisan citizen election observers. These organizations defend core political rights, including the right to vote, stand for election, assemble, express opinions, and monitor electoral processes while promoting transparency, inclusivity, and accountability. Their localized knowledge enables them to detect malpractice, ease tensions, and strengthen public confidence in elections. Recognized in instruments such as the African Charter on Democracy, Elections, and Governance (AU, 2007) and the Declaration of Principles for International Election Observation (2005), citizen observers have become indispensable actors in safeguarding electoral integrity. In 2024, election observers were declared human rights defenders by the Council for Democratic Elections at its 81st meeting (Venice, 5 December 2024) and adopted by the Venice Commission at its 141st Plenary Session.

Today, however, this democratic achievement is under threat from an authoritarian backlash. Across the continent, restrictive laws, bureaucratic hurdles, funding constraints, harassment, and criminalization increasingly undermine observer independence. In some countries, observation is permitted in law but obstructed in practice; in others, it is outright repressed. This study responds to that challenge by assessing the state of civic space for citizen election observers in 21 African countries, using eight dimensions including: legal frameworks, administrative barriers, safety, data access, and EMB relations to identify systemic barriers, enabling factors, and reform priorities needed to protect and strengthen their role in defending democracy.

2. Methodology and scope of the Study

This study employed a **qualitative, multi-method approach** designed to systematically assess the state of civic space for citizen election observers across 21 African countries, using eight defined dimensions as the analytical framework.

2.1 Data Collection Methods:

Structured questionnaires were developed for each of the eight dimensions, covering legal, administrative, operational, and safety considerations for citizen observation. These were administered through Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) with a targeted sample of election experts, civil society leaders, and former election officials from each of the 21 countries. Participants were selected for their expertise in electoral processes, civic activism, and governance, ensuring representation from both national and regional perspectives.

The qualitative interviews were supplemented by a comprehensive desk review of existing election observation reports, civic space assessments, legal analyses, and policy documents from reputable institutions such as the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (International IDEA), the Electoral Institute for Sustainable Democracy in Africa (EISA), the National Democratic Institute (NDI), and the European Union Election Observation Missions (EU EOMs). This secondary data provided historical context and allowed for triangulation of findings.

2.2 Country Selection Criteria:

The 21 countries included in the study were selected based on their having conducted national elections—or having postponed such elections—within the last five years (2019–2024). This ensured that the analysis reflected **recent and relevant electoral contexts**, while also capturing the impact of emerging political, legal, and technological developments.

No.	Country
1	Ghana
2	Nigeria
3	Kenya
4	Botswana
5	Eswatini
6	Somalia
7	Cameroon
8	Liberia
9	South Sudan
10	Somaliland
11	South Africa

12	Tanzania
13	Uganda
14	Zambia
15	Madagascar
16	Tunisia
17	Cote d'Ivoire
18	Chad
19	Congo Brazaville
20	Ethiopia
21	Zimbabwe

2.3 Scoring Framework:

Each country was assessed against the eight dimensions using a **0–10 rating scale** aligned to five civic space categories:

Score	Category	Definition
0-2	Closed	The space is severely restricted, and citizen observers are virtually unable to carry out their activities. Severe legal and administrative sanctions are applied to restrict citizen observers.
3 - 4	Repressed/Threatened	Serious restrictions exist, with high levels of physical threats, intimidation, harassment, and arrests. The environment is very hostile to citizen observers.
5 - 6:	Obstructed	Citizen observers can function but with legal and administrative restrictions that limit their ability to operate freely. Observation activities are subject to close scrutiny.
7 - 8:	Restricted	Citizen observers can operate to some extent but must navigate a regulated environment with some light restrictions. Limitations exist, but they do not pose major threats.
9 - 10:	Open/Free	Citizen observers enjoy almost complete freedom to conduct their activities. The environment is generally supportive with few or no restrictions.

These scores were informed by both qualitative judgments from interviewees and documentary evidence from official election reports. A composite score was calculated for each country, with the mean score used to position it within the five civic space categories.

2.4 Dimensions:

The eight dimensions used in this assessment are anchored in established international norms and best practices for election observation, including the *African Charter on Democracy, Elections, and Governance* (AU, 2007) and the *Declaration of Principles for International Election Observation* (2005). They reflect a holistic understanding that credible citizen election observation extends far beyond the events of election day. The ability of observers to contribute meaningfully to electoral integrity is deeply influenced by the political climate, legal frameworks, institutional arrangements, and the overall state of civic space in which they operate.

Each dimension therefore captures a critical aspect of the enabling or restrictive environment for citizen observers, encompassing regulatory provisions, administrative processes, safety conditions, access to electoral information, and the quality of engagement with Election Management Bodies (EMBs). By evaluating these interconnected parameters, the framework provides a comprehensive picture of the structural and operational realities that shape whether citizen observers can function independently, safely, and effectively in safeguarding democracy.

Dimension	Parameters
Dimension 1: <i>Regulatory Framework that protects citizen observers as human rights defenders.</i>	<i>This dimension examines the laws and institutions that govern the operations of civil society organisations/not for Profit Organisations/Non-Governmental Organisations.</i>
Dimension 2: <i>Administrative Constraints.</i>	<i>This looks at accreditation for citizen election observers that was once relatively easy. It includes the burdensome accreditation procedures and other bureaucracies that have been imposed on citizen observers.</i>
Dimension 3: <i>Relationship between Citizen Observer Organisations and the Electoral Management Body.</i>	<i>This dimension examines the nature of relationship between EMBs and Citizen Observer Organisations and whether they are able to observe all critical aspects of the electoral process.</i>
Dimension 4: <i>Safety and Wellbeing of Citizen Observers:</i>	<i>This dimension examines the use of legal and illegal mechanisms that threaten the work of citizen observers' organisations, leaders of observers' organisations, their staff and the volunteers (LTOs & STOs)</i>
Dimension 5: <i>Access to Election Data/Information.</i>	<i>This dimension examines the procedures in place for citizen observers/observers'</i>

	<i>organisations to access information on election management and processes.</i>
Dimension 6: <i>Access to Funding</i>	<i>This dimension examines the freedom of citizen observers to mobilise funding for election observation. The type of sources of funding available and whether these sources are open or controlled.</i>
Dimension 7: <i>Dialogue And Consultation on Post-Election Follow up with relevant government institutions.</i>	<i>This dimension examines the platforms available for citizen observers to engage relevant government institutions including the EMB on observation recommendations and electoral reforms.</i>
Dimension 8. <i>Perception towards Citizen Observers.</i>	<i>This dimension examines the perception of the ruling party/regime, political parties in opposition, the media and general public on the role of citizen observers in democracy and the credibility of elections.</i>

3.0 Findings, Analysis and Recommendations

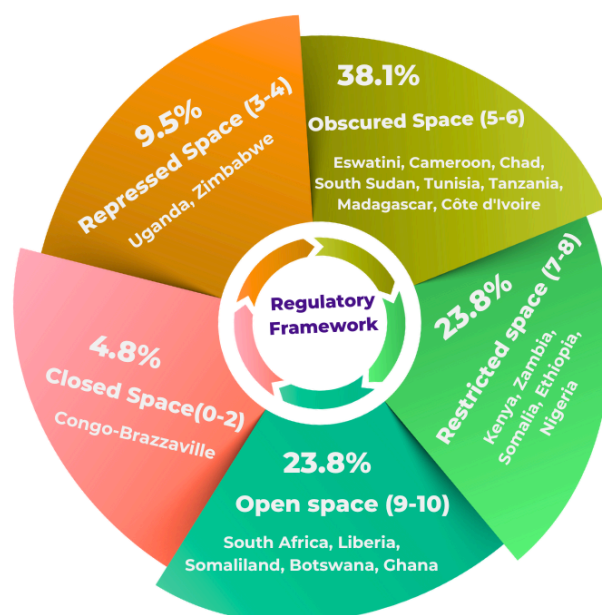
This section presents the analytical findings of civic space for citizen election observers with focus on the 8 dimensions.

3.1 Dimension1: Regulatory Frameworks and Civic Space for Citizen Observers in Africa

The regulatory environment in which citizen election observers operate across Africa is a crucial determinant of the integrity and inclusivity of electoral processes. Citizen observer organizations typically civil society groups play a vital role in enhancing electoral transparency, building public confidence, and deterring malpractice. However, the degree to which they can operate freely is dictated by a combination of laws, political will, and institutional arrangements, which vary significantly across the continent.

This section assesses **Dimension 1: Regulatory Frameworks**, focusing on the legal, administrative, and institutional constraints faced by citizen observers. It draws from a 21-country comparative dataset (2024), expert analyses, and recent literature to provide regional patterns, case studies, and actionable recommendations.

Figure 1: Regulatory Framework Ratings Overview



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

The data from the assessment on the regulatory landscape for citizen election observers across 21 African countries reveals a concerning trend of limited civic space.

- Only **23.8%** of countries provide an **open environment**. These include South Africa, Liberia, Ghana where legal frameworks actively support observer engagement.
- Another **23.8%** operate under **restricted conditions** (Kenya, Zambia, Somalia, Ethiopia and Nigeria) offering some legal protections but with notable limitations, often dependent on political goodwill.
- A significant **38.1%** of countries fall into the **obstructed** category (Eswatini, Cameroon, Chad, South Sudan, Tunisia, Tanzania, Madagascar, Cote d'Ivoire), where ambiguous laws, bureaucratic red tape, and selective enforcement hinder observer activities. More alarmingly,
- **9.5%** of countries are **repressed or threatened**, such as Uganda and Zimbabwe, where legal frameworks are weaponized against observers.
- Lastly, **4.8%** notably Congo-Brazzaville has a **closed environment**, reflecting systemic suppression of civil society. This distribution underscores the urgent need for regional legal reforms and continental norms that ensure the safety, independence, and legitimacy of citizen observation efforts across Africa.

3.1.1 Key Constraints Identified

a. Bureaucratic Registration and Renewals

In countries such as Uganda and Ethiopia, CSOs face arduous registration processes requiring annual approvals, background vetting, or state-aligned partnerships. These procedures create de facto tools for delaying operations or denying registration outright for groups critical of the government (Freedom House, 2023).

b. Legal Sanctions and Penal Codes

Laws governing “subversion,” “unlawful assembly,” or “undermining the state” are regularly invoked to criminalize civic action. In Zimbabwe, authorities used Section 66 of the Electoral Act to raid NGOs, claiming they were illegally collating election results—despite formal observer accreditation (Amnesty International, 2023).

c. Anti-Terror and Financial Laws

In Nigeria, Uganda, and Tanzania, anti-money laundering and counter-terrorism legislation have been weaponized to restrict funding. Banks are often instructed to freeze accounts of groups receiving international donor support—limiting observer organizations’ ability to deploy staff or procure election materials (CIVICUS Monitor, 2024).

3.1.2 Legal Weaponization: Selective Enforcement

Legal frameworks are often applied unequally depending on political alignment.

In Uganda, the National NGO Bureau suspended and deregistered numerous NGOs for alleged non-compliance with financial and administrative regulations. Rights groups argue that these measures, carried out under the guise of non-compliance, formed part of a broader state strategy to suppress independent electoral monitoring ahead of the 2021 general elections.

In Cameroon, pro-government “NGOs” operate freely while independent observer groups are blocked from accreditation or face delays in license approvals⁴.

3.1.3 Case Studies

Best Practice: South Africa

South Africa (9/10) remains a continental leader in civic space protection. The Nonprofit Organisations Act, 1997 offers a clear, enabling framework, while the Independent Electoral Commission (IEC) maintains formalized partnerships with civil society. There is no punitive legislation targeting observation, and post-election debriefs are routine and collaborative (MyVoteCounts, 2022).

⁴ NDI (2022). *Cameroon Electoral Observation Assessment*

Worst Practice: Uganda & Zimbabwe

Uganda scored **3/10** due to mass arrests of observers (27 detained in January 2021), closure of civil society groups like Chapter Four, and weaponization of NGO and public order laws. Civil society reports note widespread fear among LTOs/STOs⁵.

Zimbabwe scored **3/10** after police raided offices of the Zimbabwe Election Support Network (ZESN) and Election Resource Centre (ERC), seizing 93 phones and 38 laptops. Authorities accused them of illegally tabulating votes despite legal observer accreditation. This reflects deep state suspicion and legal manipulation⁶.

Public Awareness and Understanding of the Legal Framework

Studies in Zambia, Kenya, and Gambia reveal low public understanding of the legal limitations facing observers. Many citizens believe observers are government agents or UN staff. This confusion undermines trust and affects engagement.

According to Laura Grace (NDI, 2024), public awareness and legal literacy campaigns are crucial to increasing observer impact and community protection. The UN Electoral Assistance Division (2024) also emphasizes that domestic observer networks must be supported through tailored legal frameworks and safeguards.

The regulatory frameworks for election observation in Africa reflect broader trends in civic freedom and political openness. While progress exists, too many countries still use the law as a tool of control rather than facilitation.

3.1.4 Recommendations:

1. **Simplify and digitize CSO registration systems** to reduce bureaucratic barriers.
2. **Decriminalize civic engagement** by reviewing laws around subversion and public assembly.
3. **Protect observer funding sources**, especially from politically motivated financial laws.
4. **Establish formal engagement platforms** between observers and Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs).

⁵ Human Rights Watch (2021). *Uganda: Widespread Arrests of Election Observers*

⁶ VOA News (2023). *Zimbabwe Police Raid Observer Groups Over Election Monitoring*

5. **Raise public awareness** of the role of citizen observers to increase legitimacy and protection.

3.2 Dimension 2: Administrative Constraints on Citizen Election

Observation in Africa

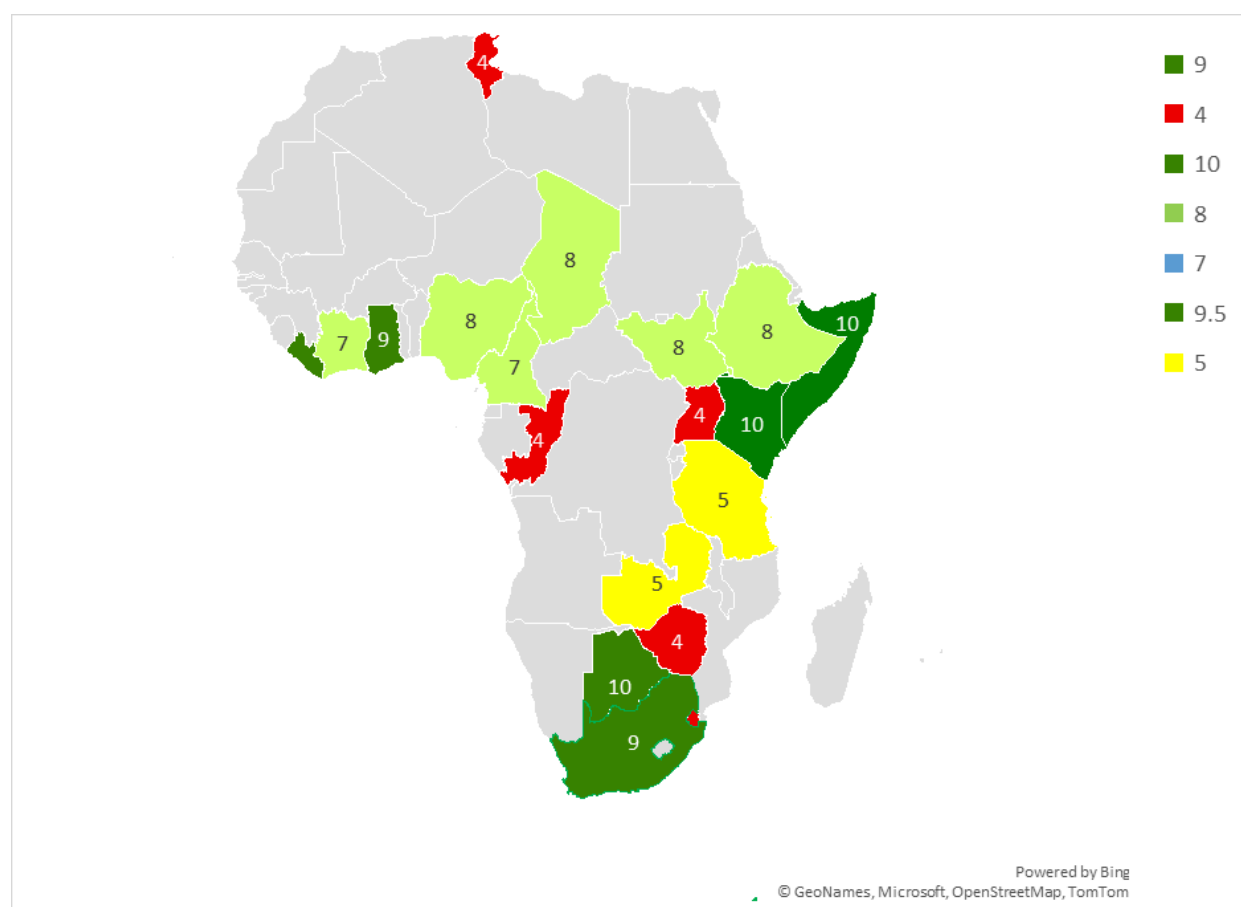
Subjecting observers to administrative requirements is essential to ensure that observation is conducted in a structured, lawful, and credible manner. These requirements help election management bodies (EMBs) to coordinate logistics, maintain security, and uphold the impartiality and professionalism of observers during sensitive electoral periods.

Administrative requirements commonly imposed on citizen election observers include mandatory accreditation by the EMB, submission of observation plans, commitment to codes of conduct, and identification of observers among others.

Across Africa, the accreditation process for citizen election observers has become increasingly restrictive, reflecting deeper political and administrative trends aimed at weakening domestic oversight. Many governments now impose excessive delays, unclear or high fees, and opaque procedures that disadvantage local observers. In some cases, domestic monitors are even barred from key locations like polling stations or tally centers, undermining their ability to ensure credible elections and eroding public trust in the process.

Assessment across the 21 countries of the study reveals varying access from a few countries offering transparent, affordable, and predictable accreditation processes, to others exhibit closed or manipulated systems where access is limited or denied. Most countries fall into the obstructed or restricted categories, where logistical, legal, and procedural barriers hinder effective observation. These trends are closely tied to broader patterns of shrinking civic space and declining democratic accountability, as states exploit administrative mechanisms to suppress critical electoral oversight.

Figure 2: Country-Level Administrative Constraints ratings and trends



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

3.2.1 Trends in Administrative Burdens on Citizen Observers

The findings reveal significant variation in the administrative ease or difficulty associated with accrediting citizen election observers.

Countries with **high scores** such as:

- Botswana (10)
- Somaliland (10)
- Ethiopia (10)
- Kenya (10),
- Liberia (9.5)
- South Africa(9)
- Ghana (9),

Exemplify open environments where accreditation processes are transparent, predictable, and often digitized. In these contexts, observers enjoy streamlined access to polling stations, tabulation centers, and critical observation points, fostering credible and inclusive electoral monitoring.

The countries operating under **restrictive administrative constraints** such as:

- **Chad (8)**
- **Ethiopia (8)**
- **South Sudan (8)**
- **Nigeria (7)**
- **Senegal (7)**

Demonstrate strong procedural frameworks, with statutory deadlines and clear documentation requirements, although logistical barriers occasionally persist in rural or conflict-prone regions.

However, most countries fall into **obstructed or repressed categories**, where administrative burdens significantly hamper observation efforts. Countries such as:

- **Tanzania (5)**
- **Zambia (5)**

Present mixed environments where the legal right to observe exists but is weakened by bureaucratic inefficiencies, sudden procedural changes, or regional inconsistencies.

At the bottom of the spectrum are countries such as:

- Zimbabwe (4)
- Eswatini (4)
- Uganda (4)
- Congo Brazzaville (4)
- Tunisia (4)

Where accreditation is either routinely denied or deliberately delayed, with domestic observers facing discriminatory procedures not applied to international counterparts. These include requirements for security clearance, shortened application windows, and opaque documentation processes. Financial barriers, both direct and indirect, further compound these challenges.

A notable case is Zimbabwe, where the Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) imposed accreditation fees during the 2023 elections amounting to US\$100 for domestic observers, US\$200 for regional observers, and US\$300 for international observers. These costs disproportionately affected grassroots organizations and created a chilling effect on civic participation, **especially when paired with short timelines and limited recourse for appeal.**

According to the NDI Global Review (2024), such administrative tactics represent a form of “soft repression,” designed to limit electoral scrutiny while maintaining the appearance of legality. The ICNL (2023) reports that over 60% of observer organizations identified accreditation delays or denials as their top challenge. Meanwhile, the Venice Commission (2024) highlights that differential treatment of observers violates international democratic norms.

The administrative environment for citizen observers is highly uneven. While some countries uphold democratic standards through fair and open systems, others obscure access through delay, complexity, or deliberate opacity.

3.2.2 Recommendations

1. **Standardize Accreditation Procedures Regionally:** Adopt AU/REC-level accreditation benchmarks with fixed timelines, transparent criteria, and statutory appeal mechanisms to reduce arbitrary delays and denials.
2. **Eliminate Financial Barriers:** Cap or abolish accreditation fees for domestic observers, following Botswana and Somaliland's free-access models to prevent exclusion of grassroots CSOs.
3. **Digitize and Decentralize Processes:** Implement online application systems and decentralized accreditation offices to speed up processing and ensure equitable access in rural/conflict-affected regions (IFES best practice examples).
4. **Ban Discriminatory Requirements:** Prohibit security clearance and other non-essential administrative hurdles that disproportionately target domestic observers.
5. **Introduce Accreditation Audits:** Mandate EMBs to publish annual accreditation statistics including approvals, denials, and reasons to promote accountability and detect patterns of "soft repression."

3.3 Dimension 3: The Relationship Between Citizen Observer Organizations and Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs)

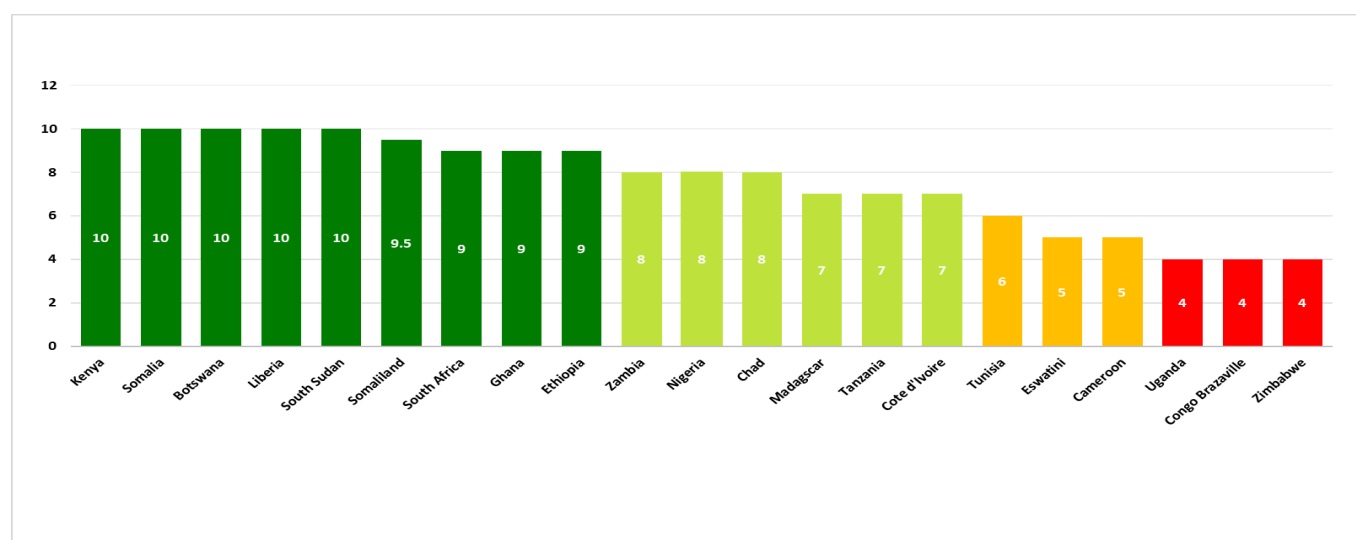
In Africa, the relationship between Election Management Bodies (EMBs) and Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) is deeply interwoven, context-specific, and often characterized by a dynamic balance of collaboration and tension/Adversarial. This relationship plays a crucial role in shaping the transparency, inclusivity, and legitimacy of electoral processes.

While EMBs are constitutionally mandated to organize and oversee elections, CSOs contribute vital democratic functions such as voter education, election observation, advocacy for electoral reform, capacity building, and dispute resolution support. The synergy or lack thereof between these two actors significantly impacts electoral credibility.

As highlighted in several recent African elections, positive EMB-CSO relationships enhance voter trust and create checks and balances that deter electoral manipulation. Conversely, strained relationships rooted in mistrust, political suspicion, and legal restrictions can weaken electoral integrity and erode public confidence. This dimension examines the nature of these relationships across 19

African countries, supported by dataset evidence, scholarly literature, and desktop research.

Figure 3: Country-Level Analysis



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

The chart, when viewed through the lens of Dimension 3: The Relationship Between Citizen Observer Organizations and Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs), highlights significant variation in institutional collaboration across African countries.

From the 21 Countries assessed, **eight scored between 9 and 10**; these included:

- Botswana
- Kenya
- Liberia
- Somalia
- Ghana
- South Sudan
- Somaliland
- Ethiopia

Reflecting **strong, structured relationships** between observer organizations and EMBs. These high scores indicate environments where CSOs enjoy formal recognition, are actively engaged and regularly consulted on electoral processes, involved in co-development of voter education and reforms and benefit from open communication channels and mutual recognition of roles they play.

3.3.1 Case Studies

Ghana: Institutionalized Engagement

Ghana's Electoral Commission (ECG) maintains long-standing partnerships with domestic observers like the Coalition of Domestic Election Observers (CODEO). Since 2000, CODEO has been integrated into voter education, accreditation, and

result verification processes. CODEO's election findings are frequently acknowledged by the ECG, contributing directly to policy recommendations (Bittiger, 2005; Afrobarometer, 2023). This strategic cooperation is a cornerstone of Ghana's consistently credible elections.

Kenya: Civic-Tech Synergy

In Kenya, the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC) partners with digital platforms like Uchaguzi, which enables real-time citizen reporting on election issues. While challenges persist such as delayed, non-machine-readable results, the IEBC's open stance toward CSOs fosters innovation and trust. According to the Carter Center (2022), Kenya's observer inclusion has set a precedent for digital civic engagement during elections.

In contrast, **six countries had restricted relationships**, including:

- Nigeria
- Tanzania
- Zambia
- Madagascar
- Chad
- Cote d'Ivoire

These are places where there is formal recognition between citizen observers and EMBs but the formal terms inconsistently implemented. These nations **scored between 7 and 8**, indicating a restricted civic space where cooperation is possible but often compromised by bureaucratic red tape, limited transparency, and political interference. For instance, in Nigeria, respected domestic groups like Yiaga Africa are routinely accredited, yet face delays in responses from INEC, especially when raising sensitive electoral integrity concerns (Yiaga Africa, 2023). Similarly, Tanzania's NEC often invites observers to consultative sessions only after major electoral decisions have already been made, reducing the practical value of engagement (NDI, 2022). These systems tend to treat observers as supplemental rather than essential democratic stakeholders, resulting in tokenistic rather than meaningful inclusion.

Other countries had **Obstructed and Repressive Relationships** (Ratings: **5–6 and 3–4**):

- Cameroon
- Tunisia
- Eswatini
- Uganda
- Zimbabwe
- Congo-Brazzaville

These are places where observer groups operate under heavy scrutiny and conditional access. EMBs often associate independent observers with opposition

politics, leading to limited or delayed accreditation, surveillance, and marginalization from official platforms.

In Tunisia, for example, the Independent High Authority for Elections (ISIE) denied accreditation to key domestic organizations such as I Watch and Mourakiboun, citing vague allegations of “foreign funding” (Human Rights Watch, 2024).

Meanwhile, Uganda, Zimbabwe, and Congo-Brazzaville, rated 3–4, reflect repressive environments, where observers face arrest, threats, and institutional exclusion. In Uganda’s 2021 elections, 27 accredited observers were detained, and the National Election Watch was forcibly shut down, with funding sources frozen to incapacitate their operations (HRW, 2021). Likewise, in Zimbabwe, raids on CSO offices led to the arrest of 41 observers by police accusing them of “illegally tabulating results,” demonstrating a deeply hostile stance toward civil oversight (Amnesty International, 2023).

3.3.2 Recommendations

1. Institutionalize Observer–EMB Engagement Frameworks

Governments and EMBs should formalize relationships with citizen observer groups through Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs), advisory councils, or joint electoral task forces. Models like Ghana’s partnership with CODEO show how embedding CSOs into electoral processes (e.g., accreditation, voter education, and reforms) leads to mutual trust, improved transparency, and stronger electoral credibility.

2. Guarantee Legal Recognition and Accreditation Rights

Countries with obstructed or repressive ratings should reform laws and policies to ensure CSOs are legally recognized as electoral stakeholders with a guaranteed right to observe, critique, and recommend reforms. Governments should repeal vague or restrictive laws used to deny accreditation (e.g., Tunisia’s ISIE actions against I Watch) and instead adopt best practices from countries like Kenya, where observer roles are formally protected.

3. Promote Continuous and Structured Dialogue

Post-election consultations should not be episodic or at the discretion of EMBs, but rather built into the electoral cycle through structured mechanisms. Countries like Tanzania and Nigeria should move beyond reactive engagement to adopt standing platforms for EMB–CSO consultation, including during inter-election periods to address structural reforms.

4. Enhance EMB Capacity for Stakeholder Management

Many EMBs lack the technical and institutional frameworks to manage relationships with CSOs consistently and transparently. Development partners and regional bodies like the AU and ECOWAS should invest in capacity building for EMBs in stakeholder relations, especially in countries transitioning from conflict or authoritarian legacies.

5. Protect Observers from Retaliation and Criminalization

Governments must uphold constitutional and international protections for observers, including freedom of association and expression. In repressive contexts like Uganda and Zimbabwe, regional human rights bodies (e.g., ACHPR, African Court) should be engaged to condemn arrests, support legal redress, and monitor reprisals against observers.

6. Foster EMB–Civic Tech Partnerships

As demonstrated in Kenya’s collaboration with Uchaguzi, EMBs should leverage civic technology tools developed by CSOs for real-time monitoring, voter reporting, and data visualization. This expands transparency and public engagement while building a co-regulatory ecosystem that strengthens electoral integrity.

7. Encourage Regional Norms and Peer Learning

Continental and regional election bodies (e.g., AU-EOM, EISA, ECONEC) should establish benchmarks and host peer exchange platforms where EMBs and CSOs from high-performing countries (e.g., Ghana, Botswana) can share lessons with counterparts from restricted or obstructed spaces. These platforms can incentivize institutional reforms by highlighting the democratic dividends of EMB–observer cooperation.

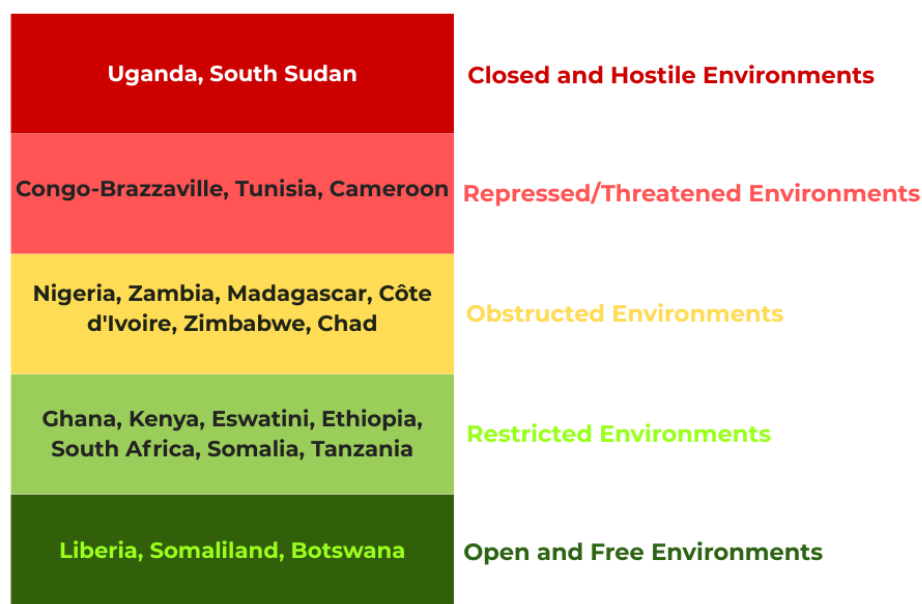
3.4 Dimension 4: Safety and Wellbeing of Citizen Election Observers in Africa

The ability of citizen election observers to operate freely, safely, and independently is a cornerstone of democratic integrity. Observers are not only watchdogs of the electoral process but also human rights defenders who contribute to peaceful transitions of power, civic accountability, and transparency. However, in many African countries, their safety and wellbeing remain precarious, undermined by both formal and informal threats.

In the African context, observers have increasingly become targets of state control, party intimidation, or legal repression. While observer rights are acknowledged in theory, in practice “observers operate under a shadow of suspicion, often denied institutional protection or access to remedies.” The African Commission on Human and Peoples’ Rights (ACHPR) also warns that in high-stakes elections, election observers are seen as adversaries, not partners, particularly when their reports are critical of the electoral management body or ruling party.

Using data from the study's 21 countries, this dimension assesses and classifies observer environments on a 0–10 scale, reflecting the presence (or absence) of legal protections, the prevalence of threats or violence, and the degree to which observers can operate freely.

Figure 4: Heatmap showing Safety and Wellbeing of Citizen election observers assessed countries.



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

The safety and freedom of citizen election observers vary dramatically, revealing deep structural and political differences in how governments perceive and permit electoral oversight. The countries that fall into the **Open and Free Environments**:

- Liberia
- Somaliland
- Botswana

Reflect best practices in democratic inclusion. These nations provide legal protections, transparent accreditation systems, and logistical support for observers. For instance, Liberia's National Elections Commission (NEC) has consistently partnered with civil society in monitoring and reform processes, with peaceful and unhindered observation reported during the 2023 elections (IFES Liberia, 2023). In Somaliland, organizations like SONSAF play a leading role in post-election peacebuilding and reporting, demonstrating how even unrecognized or fragile democracies can support civic oversight (Saferworld, 2021). Botswana continues to exemplify institutional trust and operational independence for observer groups (EISA, 2022).

In **Restricted Environments**:

- Ghana
- Kenya

- Eswatini
- Ethiopia
- South Africa
- Somalia
- Tanzania

egal frameworks are generally in place and supportive, but political volatility and inconsistent enforcement introduce risks. While countries like Ghana have built institutionalized partnerships between the Electoral Commission and domestic observers like CODEO (Afrobarometer, 2023), challenges such as party intimidation or regional access barriers persist. Kenya's civic-tech innovations like Uchaguzi are globally recognized, but observers still report localized threats in politically sensitive regions (Carter Center, 2022). South Africa's municipal elections in 2021 also exposed access challenges due to localized gatekeeping, despite strong national frameworks (EISA, 2022). In Ethiopia and Somalia, observers face heightened risks in conflict-affected areas, even though the legal recognition of civil society's role remains (UNSOM, 2022).

The **Obstructed Environments**:

- Nigeria
- Zambia
- Madagascar
- Côte d'Ivoire
- Zimbabwe
- Chad

Highlight systemic and operational constraints, where observers are permitted but restricted in practice. Common issues include last-minute accreditation denials, media smear campaigns, state surveillance, and in some cases, direct physical attacks. During Nigeria's 2023 elections, monitors reported blocked access to collation centers and physical threats in areas like Lagos and Rivers (Premium Times, 2023). In Zimbabwe, 41 observers from ZESN and ERC were arrested in a high-profile police operation, accused of unlawfully tabulating results (Human Rights Watch, 2023). Côte d'Ivoire, still affected by post-conflict fragility, limits observer mobility and access, particularly in rural zones (NDI, 2021). These contexts suggest a trend of legal tolerance but operational hostility.

At the bottom of the scale are the **Repressed and Closed Environments**:

- Tunisia
- Cameroon
- Congo-Brazzaville

Where observation is effectively criminalized or treated with hostility. They exhibit institutionalized suspicion, with Tunisia's Independent High Authority for Elections (ISIE) denying accreditation to reputable groups like I Watch and Mourakiboun, citing "foreign funding" as a pretext (Human Rights Watch, 2024). Cameroon

observers encounter military intimidation and surveillance, particularly in Anglophone regions (International Crisis Group, 2021).

In the most **hostile environments**:

- Uganda
- South Sudan

State repression is severe. Uganda's 2021 elections saw 27 observers arrested and NGOs dissolved or financially frozen, effectively dismantling independent oversight (HRW, 2021). South Sudan lacks any formal process for citizen observation and maintains tight military control over public space (UNMISS, 2022). These countries weaponize the law, security agencies, and bureaucratic controls to silence electoral scrutiny, threatening democracy itself.

3.4.1 Case Studies

Uganda – A Repressive and Hostile Environment for Citizen Election Observers

Uganda presents one of the severely harsh environments for citizen election observers in Africa, scoring just 2 out of 10 on the safety scale. The 2021 general elections were marked by a systematic state-led crackdown on civil society. On election day, 27 accredited observers were arrested in Kampala while coordinating data collection, an operation widely viewed as a deliberate attempt to suppress electoral oversight.

In the lead-up to the vote, the National NGO Bureau disbanded National Election Watch Uganda (NEW-U) and froze the bank accounts of prominent CSOs, including UNNGOF, UWONET, and Chapter Four Uganda. These organizations were central to domestic election observation. Their closure and financial incapacitation coupled with arrests and surveillance highlighted a broader effort to intimidate and dismantle civic actors. Restrictive laws such as the Public Order Management Act and the NGO Act (2016) and COVID-restrictions were weaponized to legitimize repression.

The crackdown also targeted international support. The EU's technical advisor on election and a Kenyan IFES official were both deported. Legal challenges by affected CSOs were met with judicial inaction, underscoring the absence of institutional recourse. Uganda's 2021 elections illustrate how legal tools, state violence, and administrative repression can be orchestrated to undermine citizen observation and restrict democratic accountability.

The safety of citizen observers remains highly variable across Africa. While a few countries offer safe, enabling environments, many still criminalize independent monitoring, especially during contested elections. Legal recognition alone is not sufficient; without enforcement and political will, observers remain vulnerable.

3.4.2 Recommendations

1. Strengthen Legal and Institutional Frameworks for Observation: Governments should adopt and enforce clear legal provisions that guarantee the rights of citizen

observers, including timely accreditation, freedom of movement, and protection from retaliation. Open and Free environments like Liberia and Botswana show that institutionalizing observer participation through laws and electoral commission partnerships contributes to peaceful, credible elections.

2. Establish Independent Accreditation Mechanisms: Accreditation processes should be depoliticized and managed by independent electoral bodies with transparent guidelines and timelines. In Obstructed Environments such as Nigeria and Zimbabwe, last-minute or arbitrary accreditation denials were used to restrict observation, undermining election credibility.

3. Promote Multi-Stakeholder Protection Protocols: Develop coordinated protection frameworks involving electoral commissions, civil society, human rights bodies, and security agencies to ensure observers' physical safety and operational security. Observers in countries like Ethiopia, Somalia, and Uganda operate in high-risk environments where their safety cannot be guaranteed without broader institutional support.

4. Leverage Regional Peer Pressure and Accountability Mechanisms: The African Union and regional economic communities (e.g., ECOWAS, SADC, EAC) should establish observer protection benchmarks and publicly name and shame countries violating observer rights. Countries in Repressed and Closed environments often disregard international standards unless confronted with coordinated regional pressure and diplomatic consequences.

5. Support Civic-Tech Innovations and Remote Observation: Invest in technology-enabled observation tools (e.g., mobile-based reporting apps, open data dashboards) to bypass physical and bureaucratic restrictions. Kenya's *Uchaguzi* demonstrates the potential of civic tech to enhance real-time monitoring even in politically tense regions.

6. Protect Civic Space Through International Solidarity: Donors, INGOs, and UN agencies should increase funding and legal protection for domestic observer groups, particularly those facing closure or criminalization. In Uganda and South Sudan, the dismantling of CSOs under the guise of "foreign interference" reflects a growing tactic of state repression that requires an international response.

7. Institutionalize Post-Election Learning and Reform: Electoral commissions and governments should commit to structured post-election reviews with observer groups to address lessons learned and systemic weaknesses. Post-election dialogue platforms, such as those facilitated in Somaliland by SONSAF, promote trust-building and continuous improvement in electoral processes.

By adopting these recommendations, African governments and electoral stakeholders can help transform hostile and obstructed environments into enabling spaces for electoral oversight, fostering public trust and democratic resilience.

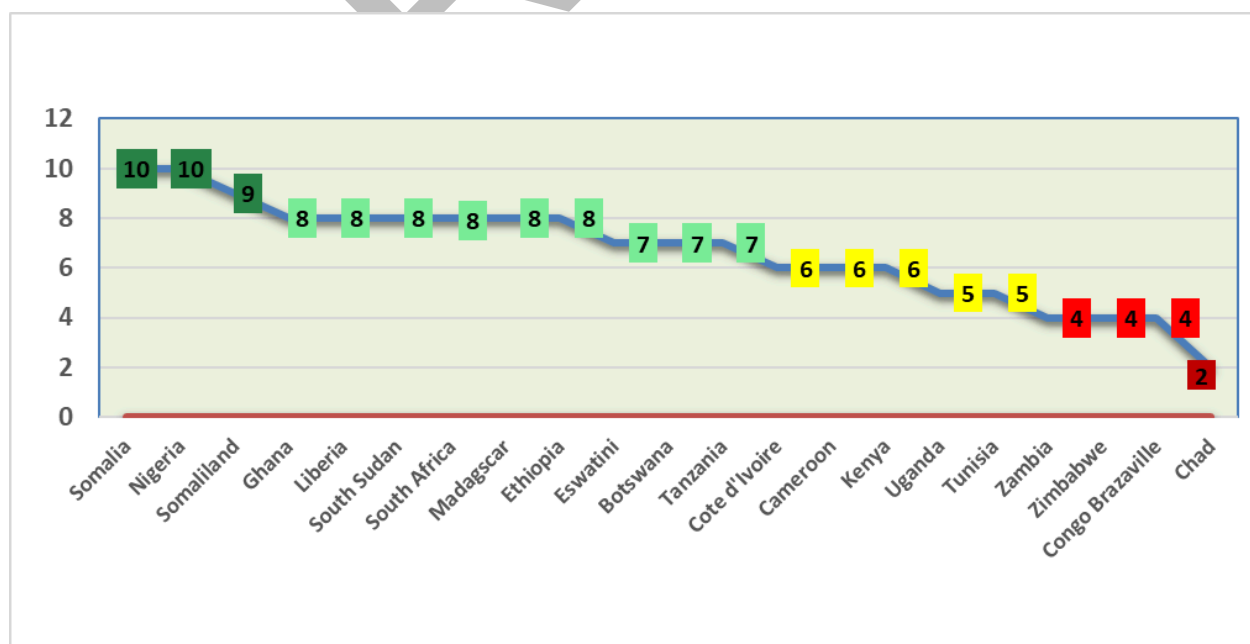
3.5 Dimension 5: Access to Election Data and Information: A Prerequisite for Transparent Citizen Observation

In any electoral process, the ability of citizen observers to access timely, comprehensive, and disaggregated election data is foundational to ensuring transparency and accountability. Access to information such as voter rolls, lists of polling stations, and results broken down by polling station empowers observer groups to evaluate electoral credibility, identify irregularities, and instil public confidence in democratic processes.

International standards including the Declaration of Principles for International Election Observation (2005) and the African Union Guidelines for Electoral Observation recognize the right to access electoral data as essential for independent verification. Yet, in Africa, the quality, timeliness, and format of this access remains uneven and often inadequate.

Transparent data access is a cornerstone of credible elections. It enables citizen observers to verify voter rolls, track polling station results, and detect anomalies. This section analyzes **Dimension 5: Access to Election Data/Information**, drawing on assessment ratings, scholarly resources, and online -sourced examples to evaluate openness across 21 African countries.

Figure 5: Graph showing access to electoral data by assessed countries



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

3.5.1 Progress in Some Countries

Several African countries are making commendable strides in enhancing transparency through improved access to electoral data. These countries demonstrate that, when access to timely, disaggregated, and analysable data is prioritized, citizen observation becomes significantly more effective and credible.

- **Nigeria** has emerged as a continental leader in electoral data openness with a highest rating of 10. Through the INEC Result Viewing Portal (IREV), the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) allows real-time publication of polling station-level results during national elections. This innovation marked a pivotal shift in transparency during the 2023 general elections, enabling observers and the public to cross-verify announced outcomes, thereby building electoral credibility and deterring manipulation.
- **Ghana** has equally demonstrated commitment to transparent electoral processes. In the 2020 elections, the Electoral Commission made voter rolls and results readily accessible, leading international observers including IFES and ECOWAS to rank Ghana's polls among the most transparent in Africa (IFES, 2021). While data formats remain largely PDF-based, the speed and consistency of publication across electoral cycles reinforce trust in the system.
- **Botswana** and **Eswatini** show moderate openness. Both countries allow accredited observers to access voter rolls and results, usually after the election period. However, limitations persist—most data is released in static formats (PDF scans), often requiring manual parsing, which impedes rapid statistical analysis or fraud detection.
- **In Kenya**, while challenges exist, efforts by the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC) to publish results from over 46,000 polling stations in 2022 were praised by international observers, including; The Carter Center and the EU Election Observation Mission. These results were uploaded on public portals for access by media, CSOs, and citizens. However, observers noted the need for commercial-grade digital infrastructure, as much of the data was in raw PDF format, limiting its analytical value (Carter Center, 2022).

Moreover, civic tech initiatives like Uchaguzi Kenya, a citizen-led election monitoring platform highlight how real-time crowd-sourced data can complement official election results. Uchaguzi geocodes and aggregates voter-reported incidents such as irregularities or violence. Yet, its accuracy and impact hinge on the availability of machine-readable EMB data, which remains inconsistent in format and frequency.

These examples underscore the positive role of digital innovations and policy reform in strengthening civic space. Platforms like Nigeria's IREV and Ghana's

digital publication portals align with international best practices, including recommendations by International IDEA, which advocates for open-data standards in election reporting to enhance civic engagement and oversight (IDEA.int).

These cases collectively illustrate that data transparency is not merely a technical issue but a political and institutional commitment. Where EMBs embrace openness, observers gain legitimacy, and electoral processes enjoy greater public trust.

3.5.2 Challenges Remain Elsewhere

While some African countries have advanced in electoral data transparency, others continue to face significant barriers that undermine the effectiveness of citizen election observation. These challenges rooted in poor data practices, legal limitations, and political opacity create environments where elections are less verifiable, and public trust is harder to sustain.

- In **Kenya**, the 2022 general elections were marked by a significant effort to release polling station results publicly. Over 46,000 forms (Form 34A) were uploaded to the IEBC portal. However, these documents were scanned PDFs with no indexing, searchability, or machine readability. As reported by the Collaboration on International ICT Policy in East and Southern Africa (CIPESA) and CISA (2022), this made it nearly impossible for citizen observers and analysts to perform timely verification or large-scale analysis. Observers described it as “data without usability”, technically transparent, but practically inaccessible.
- In **Uganda**, although observers are legally allowed to access electoral data, the practical environment is obstructed. During the 2021 elections, civil society groups such as the Uganda National NGO Forum and CCEDU reported interference, arrests, and denial of access to polling data even after being formally accredited. Human Rights Watch (2021) documented how state security services raided data centers and arrested observers on fabricated grounds, stifling their ability to collect or disseminate results.
- **Cameroon** and **Tunisia** present more systemic challenges. There are no provisions or mechanisms for releasing polling-station level results in accessible formats. Election management remains opaque, and access to voter rolls or electoral maps is heavily restricted, particularly for independent or civil society actors. These gaps reflect a broader lack of commitment to electoral transparency norms.
- In **Zimbabwe**, the Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) operates a public website that releases national and provincial results, but the polling-station level data remains unavailable. Although voter rolls are published on Nomination Court Day for candidate verification, citizen observers cannot freely download these datasets, and access often comes with financial costs. The voters’ roll is shared only in flattened PDFs, unsuitable for meaningful analysis. According to ZESN (Zimbabwe Election Support

Network) and EISA, this deliberate lack of granular data obscures irregularities, preventing detection of vote inflation or polling station tampering.

“Without polling-station results, CSOs are flying blind. You can’t detect over-voting, ghost stations, or double tallying,” said one ZESN analyst during post-2023 electoral reviews.

3.5.3 Recommendations:

1. Adopt Binding Open Data Standards for Elections: African Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs) should align with **International IDEA’s Open Electoral Data Principles** by publishing results, voter rolls, and turnout data in **machine-readable formats (CSV, JSON, XLSX)** rather than static PDFs. This ensures data usability for verification, statistical analysis, and fraud detection (IDEA.int, 2022).

2. Institutionalize Real-Time Polling Station-Level Reporting: Scale up best practices like **Nigeria’s IReV** by making real-time polling station results publication mandatory across the continent. EMBs should ensure that uploads are time-stamped, geo-referenced, and searchable to facilitate rapid civic and media oversight.

3. Strengthen Civic-Tech Integration: Partner with domestic civic-tech platforms like **Uchaguzi (Kenya)** to complement official reporting with citizen-sourced incident mapping. EMBs should provide open APIs to accredited CSOs, enabling automated verification of election results and incidents.

4. Remove Legal and Financial Barriers to Data Access: Abolish accreditation fees for accessing electoral datasets and prohibit legal provisions that restrict polling-station data from accredited observers. EMBs should guarantee **equal access for both domestic and international monitors**, including in rural and conflict zones.

5. Establish Data Transparency Audits: Regional bodies such as the AU and ECOWAS should create **annual electoral data transparency scorecards** tracking timeliness, accessibility, and granularity of published election data. Countries with persistent opacity should face peer review and targeted reform support.

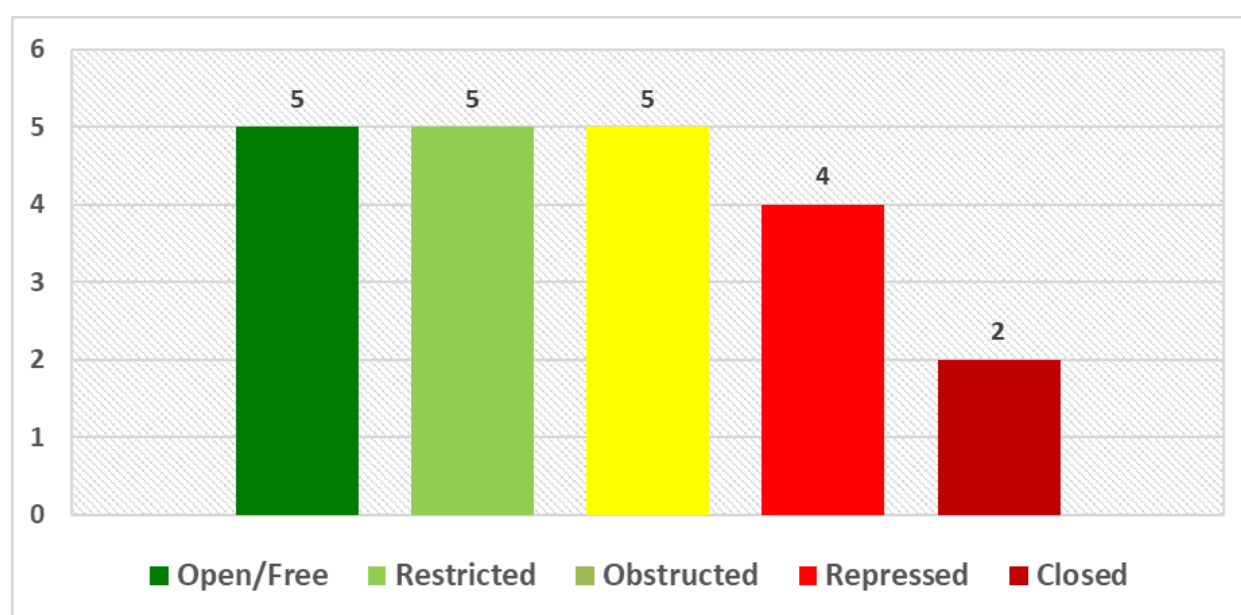
6. Build Digital Infrastructure for Elections: Invest in secure, high-capacity digital systems to handle real-time uploads and large-scale downloads, preventing the bottlenecks seen in Kenya’s 2022 elections. This includes ensuring redundancy, cybersecurity, and offline backup mechanisms.

3.6 Dimension 6: Access to Funding: Narrative Analysis of 21 African Countries

Access to funding is a vital enabler for citizen observer groups, particularly in contexts where state support is lacking or actively hostile. This dimension assesses

the freedom of citizen observers to mobilize, receive, and utilize funding, including both domestic and international sources, and identifies systemic constraints such as restrictive laws, political interference, and donor fatigue. Funding freedom is not only a financial issue, it's a governance and rights issue. According to CIVICUS (2023) and the International Center for Not-for-Profit Law (ICNL, 2022), restrictions on foreign funding are among the most widespread tactics used to shrink civic space globally, especially around sensitive political processes like elections.

Figure 6: No of countries ratings on Funding Environments for Citizen Election Observation in Africa



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

3.6.1 Access to funding Ratings Summary

The bar graph shows **5 countries rated 9–10 (23.8%)**, with **Open/Free Environments to access to funding**, namely:

- Kenya
- Liberia
- Botswana
- Zambia
- Chad
- ,

These are countries where citizen observer groups enjoy high autonomy and access to international and some domestic funding. Regulatory frameworks are enabling, allowing civil society to plan and conduct electoral monitoring with minimal state interference.

- **Kenya** has a long-established ecosystem of election-focused CSOs such as the *Elections Observation Group (ELOG)*, supported by bilateral donors including USAID, the EU, and UNDP. Although donor fatigue has become more pronounced in non-election years, regulatory interference remains minimal. The NGO Coordination Board operates under a legal framework that, while sometimes politicized, has largely permitted electoral transparency initiatives. Notably, Kenya has benefitted from international investment in digital civic innovation, including projects like *Uchaguzi*, which relies on open-source platforms and donor funding (Source: Ushahidi.org, Carter Center Reports).
- **Liberia**, a post-conflict democracy, has maintained relatively open civic space since the 2005 transition. Organizations such as *NAYMOTE*, *LEON* (Liberia Elections Observation Network), and *CEMESP* have been central to electoral oversight. These groups regularly receive funding from USAID, Open Society Foundations, and ECOWAS. There are no significant legal barriers to receiving or utilizing foreign grants, and financial reporting mechanisms are well understood by both CSOs and donors (Carter Center Liberia Reports, 2017–2023).
- In **Botswana**, observers operate under one of Africa’s most stable democratic frameworks. There is no known state interference in funding, and civil society organizations like *BIDPA* and the *Democracy Research Project* have engaged in electoral studies and monitoring. The primary challenge lies not in legal obstacles but in compressed electoral timelines, which complicate the donor disbursement cycle. Nonetheless, Botswana’s high trust in governance and donor relations has kept this space functional (Afrobarometer 2023, EISA Botswana Country Report).
- **Zambia** has shown marked improvement in civic space under the current administration (elected in 2021). The electoral environment during the 2021 general elections allowed CSOs like *GEARS Initiative Zambia* and *CCMG* to receive significant funding and operate freely. The government has pledged to review restrictive laws like the NGO Act, and there’s a growing recognition of the role observers play in electoral transparency (Source: EU EOM Zambia 2021 Final Report, UNDP Zambia).
- **Chad**, despite recurring political instability and transition, remains somewhat of an anomaly. Due to strong international peacekeeping presence and external political pressure, civil society groups have retained relative freedom to receive electoral support. International actors such as MINUSCA and the AU have funded or partnered with local CSOs to ensure transparency, particularly in high-risk contexts. However, this openness is often more a function of international oversight than internal democratic will (Source: International IDEA, 2022; African Centre for Strategic Studies).

There are **5 countries rated 7–8 (28.6%)** and operating under **Restricted Access to funding** such as:

- Nigeria
- South Africa
- Ethiopia
- Zimbabwe
- Somalia

In such contexts, CSOs working on election observation face no outright bans on funding but work in tightly regulated, politically sensitive environments where compliance burdens, political pressure, and institutional weaknesses limit their ability to mobilize and use resources effectively.

- **Nigeria** presents a classic case of indirect restriction through regulatory overreach. While CSOs are legally allowed to receive external funding, frameworks such as the Companies and Allied Matters Act (CAMA) and the Financial Reporting Council demand intensive compliance, including detailed disclosures, registration hurdles, and occasional tax scrutiny. According to the European Union Election Observation Mission (EU EOM) 2019 report, Nigerian observer groups often experience delays in funding approvals and challenges when donor activities are perceived as “political.” Nonetheless, organizations such as YIAGA Africa and CLEEN Foundation have managed to sustain partnerships with USAID, NED, and the EU through institutional resilience and legal navigation (ICNL, 2022).
- **South Africa** maintains a generally open civic environment, but election-related CSOs such as the Electoral Institute for Sustainable Democracy in Africa (EISA) and My Vote Counts report increased donor fatigue and declining funding, especially for long-term electoral reforms. Additionally, a 2020 High-Level Panel Report by the Mbeki Foundation warned of creeping distrust between state institutions and civil society over foreign influence. While legal restrictions are minimal, CSOs must adhere to complex financial transparency laws under the NPO Act, which often prove burdensome for smaller election-monitoring groups.
- In **Ethiopia**, despite constitutional protections, civic actors operate under ambiguous legal and political conditions. The Civil Society Proclamation (No. 1113/2019) replaced a much-criticized 2009 law, easing some restrictions on foreign funding. Yet, the law retains clauses requiring that at least 10% of project funding come from domestic sources, limiting flexibility. During the 2021 elections, Human Rights Watch and other observer groups noted surveillance of civic actors, particularly those working in conflict-affected areas like Tigray and Oromia. Funding to election observers is often funneled through INGOs or multilateral mechanisms to reduce exposure (Source: CSO Sustainability Index – Ethiopia, 2022).

- **Zimbabwe** exemplifies a politically tense funding environment. Although there are no official prohibitions on external support, the government often uses administrative tools and hostile rhetoric to intimidate CSOs involved in electoral transparency. Organizations such as ZESN and ERC have faced surveillance, threats, and conditional licensing. The proposed Private Voluntary Organisations (PVO) Amendment Bill, currently under review, aims to tighten government control over CSO registration and foreign funding, sparking international concern (Amnesty International, 2023; ICNL, 2022).
- **Somalia**, which appears twice in the dataset (likely due to federal vs. regional disaggregation), suffers from structural funding restrictions rooted in insecurity and weak state capacity. Most election-related funding is managed by UNDP, USAID, or other intermediaries through the UN Joint Program on Electoral Support (UNJPES). Local organizations are typically sub-grantees or implementers and have limited flexibility in fund design or execution. Security risks and clan-based tensions further restrict independent observer mobility and outreach (Source: UNSOM Electoral Assistance Updates, 2021–2023).

There are 5 countries rated **5-6 (23.8%)** and operating under **Obstructed Environments**:

- Ghana
- Tanzania
- Somaliland
- Madagascar
- South Sudan

In these countries, citizen observer groups face legal ambiguity, bureaucratic bottlenecks, and inconsistent government cooperation that obstruct their ability to mobilize or utilize electoral funding effectively. While not overtly hostile, these environments impose enough friction to weaken the scale, reach, and timing of citizen observation initiatives.

- **Ghana**, although widely recognized as a democratic leader in West Africa, suffers from donor dependency and bureaucratic delays. During non-election years, domestic philanthropic interest is virtually absent, and observer groups often lack core funding to maintain readiness. Organizations like the *Coalition of Domestic Election Observers (CODEO)* rely heavily on donor support, primarily from USAID and the EU. However, funding often arrives late in the electoral cycle, compromising pre-election assessments and long-term observation. The lack of structured public funding mechanisms for civic work is a persistent barrier (Source: International IDEA, 2022; EU EOM Ghana, 2020).
- In **Tanzania**, the government maintains tight control over civil society funding, especially for election-related work. CSOs are subject to rigorous

financial reporting and prior approval requirements under the NGO Act (2002) and Political Parties Act (2019). The state can arbitrarily reject donor-funded initiatives deemed “political.” According to *CIVICUS Monitor* (2023), several organizations working on civic education or electoral monitoring have faced suspensions, deregistrations, or sudden tax audits. This has led many donor agencies to scale back or redirect support through international intermediaries.

- **Somaliland**, a self-declared independent region of Somalia, has earned praise for its democratic experiments, including holding competitive elections. However, the absence of international recognition and reliance on informal institutions create financial fragility. Observer groups like *SONSAF* and *Safenet* often operate through support from NGOs such as Progressio or UNDP-aligned platforms. Although there's political will for civic engagement, the lack of institutionalized funding channels forces local CSOs to operate project-to-project and often with limited logistical scale (Source: Interpeace & DRI, 2021; Africa Portal, 2023).
- In **Madagascar**, civil society plays an active role in elections, but funding is hindered by inconsistent donor presence and restrictive project approval processes. CSOs like *KMF/CNOE* (national observer network) rely heavily on EU and USAID assistance. However, complex approval processes for foreign funding through the Ministry of Interior can delay project implementation. Transparency International noted that regulatory opacity discourages smaller civic actors from engaging in election-related work.⁷
- **South Sudan** is one of the most fragile states in the region, and its lack of functional banking systems, volatile security situation, and poor legal infrastructure severely limits the ability of CSOs to secure and deploy funding. International donors typically bypass local institutions, channelling funds through UN agencies like UNMISS or INGOs. This means local observer groups have limited decision-making power and rarely access sustainable funding. The 2023 UN Electoral Readiness Assessment warned that without deliberate support to local civic actors, elections risk lacking credible domestic oversight (Source: UNMISS Electoral Brief, 2023; Human Rights Watch, 2022).

In countries like There are 4 countries rated 3-4 (19.0%) and operating under **Repressed/Threatened Funding Environments:**

- Eswatini
- Tunisia
- Côte d'Ivoire
- Uganda

⁷ Transparency International – Initiative Madagascar. (2023). *Rapport de suivi sur la transparence et l'intégrité des élections à Madagascar – Élections de 2022*. Antananarivo: TI-Initiative Madagascar. Retrieved from: <https://www.transparency.org>

In these contexts, access to electoral funding is politically sensitive, legally constrained, and often actively discouraged. Observer groups operate under institutional suspicion, with authorities aggressively enforcing finance laws and exerting political interference, especially when resources come from international donors or are directed toward electoral integrity and governance initiatives.

- **Eswatini**, Africa's last absolute monarchy, maintains one of the most tightly controlled civic spaces on the continent. CSOs working on democracy, elections, or human rights often operate without legal protection, and foreign donors face scrutiny under the Public Order Act and Suppression of Terrorism Act—both widely criticized for their misuse against dissenters. International support to election-related civil society is minimal and channelled through cautious, often apolitical NGOs. According to Freedom House (2023) and CIVICUS Monitor, domestic observer networks face structural underfunding and reputational risks when aligned with pro-democracy discourse.
- In **Uganda**, the 2021 elections marked a high point in the state's deliberate repression of electoral observers and civic actors receiving foreign funds. The government froze bank accounts of key CSOs including Chapter Four Uganda, UWONET, and UNNGOF on vague accusations of money laundering and subversion. Simultaneously, the National NGO Bureau deregistered several election-monitoring organizations under the NGO Act (2016) and Anti-Money Laundering Act. A Human Rights Watch report (2021) confirmed that these financial restrictions were strategically timed to limit oversight of the electoral process. International donors such as the EU, Open Society Foundations, and USAID faced direct and indirect pressure for supporting civic initiatives.
- **Côte d'Ivoire** presents a dual reality: a growing civil society sector but one heavily dependent on international donors and constrained by government control. According to the CSO Sustainability Index⁸, while legal provisions for CSOs exist, funding for politically sensitive work—including elections—requires prior governmental approval or alignment with official policy frameworks. Observer groups report self-censorship and underfunding outside presidential election years. Furthermore, the government has increasingly questioned foreign-funded projects under the guise of sovereignty and national security.
- **Tunisia**, once hailed as the Arab Spring's democratic success, has seen serious democratic backsliding since 2021. Under President Kais Saied's consolidation of power, the state has targeted NGOs with new legal measures aimed at restricting foreign funding. In 2022, the government

⁸ *USAID CSO Sustainability Index (2022): Côte d'Ivoire*

introduced draft legislation requiring CSOs to disclose and seek permission for all foreign donations, creating delays and risks of criminal penalties for non-compliance⁹. Election observers such as Mourakiboun and I-Watch have reported reduced operating capacity and loss of international partnerships due to the increasingly hostile climate.

These countries, which make up **19%** of the assessed dataset, are characterized by state-imposed limitations designed to suppress electoral scrutiny and marginalize independent funding flows. CSOs in these contexts not only struggle to access timely and adequate funding but also risk legal penalties, deregistration, or public vilification when engaging in election observation. The erosion of donor confidence, paired with legal weaponization, creates a chilling effect that undermines both domestic accountability and international cooperation.

There are 2 countries with ratings of 0-2 (9.5%) and operating under **Closed/Hostile Environments (9.5%)**:

- Cameroon
- Republic of Congo (Congo-Brazzaville)

In these countries, civil society organizations working on elections and democratic governance operate under severe restrictions, where state control over funding is not just regulatory but also politically punitive. The space for civic engagement, especially around electoral transparency, is effectively closed—marked by opaque legal frameworks, arbitrary enforcement, and active suppression of external support.

- **Cameroon** exemplifies a civic environment where foreign and independent funding is tightly controlled and routinely politicized. Under the 1990 Law on Associations, CSOs must register with administrative authorities, and their approval is subject to vague “public order” conditions. While technically legal to receive external funding, groups must seek prior authorization from the Ministry of Territorial Administration—which can deny or delay approvals at its discretion. According to CIVICUS Monitor¹⁰ (2023) and Freedom House¹¹, organizations working on election observation have faced license withdrawals, forced closures, and intrusive audits, especially around elections. During the 2018 presidential vote, independent observers were denied accreditation, and journalists covering electoral processes were harassed or detained. Many donor-funded programs must operate through religious institutions or humanitarian intermediaries to avoid political reprisal¹².

⁹ ICNL (2023). *Civic Freedom Monitor: Tunisia*

¹⁰ CIVICUS Monitor (2023). *Cameroon and Congo-Brazzaville Country Profiles*

¹¹ Freedom House (2023). *Freedom in the World: Cameroon, Congo-Brazzaville*

¹² ICNL (2022). *Civic Freedom Monitor – Cameroon*

- In the Republic of **Congo (Congo-Brazzaville)**, civil society faces a similarly hostile environment, characterized by opaque funding laws, politicized surveillance, and militarized state oversight. The 2021 presidential elections were conducted in a climate of repression and civic fear, with opposition voices and watchdog groups barred from meaningful engagement. According to the US State Department Human Rights Report (2022) and Reporters Without Borders, CSOs engaging in election observation or political rights advocacy are often branded as “destabilizing agents.” Independent funding—especially from foreign embassies or international NGOs is viewed with suspicion, and banking restrictions are used to delay or block fund transfers. Many CSOs resort to informal arrangements, risking prosecution under anti-terrorism and anti-corruption laws designed to chill dissent.

Key Characteristics of Closed Environments

- Arbitrary licensing and legal ambiguity to obstruct funding registration and use.
- Surveillance of donor-backed initiatives, especially during electoral cycles.
- Narratives framing foreign support as neo-colonial or destabilizing, fueling public suspicion and state repression.
- Donor withdrawal or rechanneling of support to indirect mechanisms (e.g., multilateral agencies, religious groups).

Cameroon and Congo-Brazzaville exemplify “closed civic space” environments, where not only is electoral observation discouraged, but access to the financial resources needed for democratic oversight is structurally and politically denied. These states fall below acceptable international standards for civil society freedoms, and their treatment of foreign-funded election programs reflects a deeper resistance to transparency and accountability. Observers in these countries must often work covertly or exit entirely, leaving elections vulnerable to manipulation without scrutiny.

Key Barriers Identified Across Contexts

- **Legal restrictions on foreign funding** (especially in repressive states)
- **Complex registration and licensing requirements**
- **Donor fatigue**, especially for electoral cycles seen as low-stakes.
- **Delays in donor disbursement**, limiting pre-election mobilization.
- **Local donor apathy**—few domestic foundations prioritize electoral oversight due to political sensitivities.

3.6.2 Recommendations to strengthen funding access for Citizen Election Observers in Africa

1. **Guarantee Legal Protections for Observer Funding:**

African governments should embed in law the right of accredited citizen observer groups to access both domestic and foreign funding without arbitrary restrictions. This should include prohibiting the misuse of anti-money laundering or counter-terrorism laws to target electoral monitoring organizations.

2. **Promote Multi-Year and Flexible Funding Models:**

Donors and regional bodies should prioritize multi-year grants that support continuous election readiness, rather than short-term project-based funding tied only to election periods. Flexible funding allows observers to conduct pre- and post-election monitoring and to maintain institutional capacity year-round.

3. **Develop Domestic Funding Ecosystems:**

To reduce over-reliance on foreign donors, governments and philanthropic networks should incentivize local giving through tax benefits, corporate social responsibility programs, and public-private partnerships. Domestic funding streams enhance sustainability and insulate observer groups from external political pressures on international funding.

4. **Enhance Donor Coordination and Regional Solidarity:**

Regional organizations such as the African Union, ECOWAS, EAC, and SADC should facilitate pooled funding platforms accessible to vetted CSOs across member states. This would help bypass restrictive national funding environments and strengthen regional peer support networks for electoral monitoring.

5. **Increase Transparency to Build Trust:**

Citizen observer groups should adopt robust financial management systems and public reporting to enhance credibility with both domestic stakeholders and international donors. Demonstrating accountability reduces the risk of politically motivated funding restrictions and increases donor confidence.

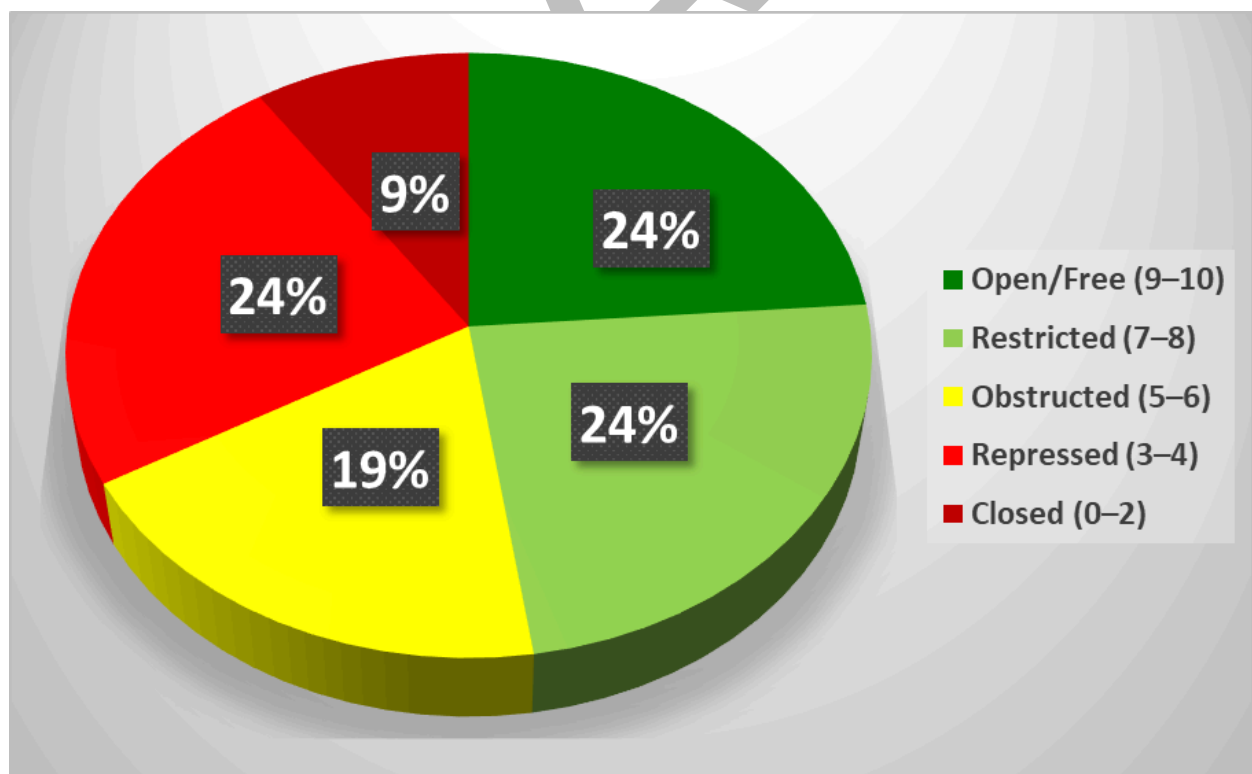
3.7 Dimension 7: Dialogue and Consultation on Post-Election Follow-up

Post-election engagement between civil society organizations (CSOs) and state institutions, particularly Election Management Bodies (EMBs) is essential to improving democratic processes. The post-election period offers a strategic window to assess electoral shortcomings, suggest reforms, and strengthen electoral integrity. However, across Africa, the quality, openness, and permanence of these consultation platforms vary significantly by political context and institutional will.

According to International IDEA¹³, structured dialogue spaces can transform post-election tensions into democratic learning moments. Conversely, when dialogue is episodic, antagonistic, or tokenistic, observers' recommendations are ignored, fostering public distrust and stagnation in reform.

The analysis categorizes the 21 countries into five levels of openness based on their rating (0–10 scale), indicating the **freedom and quality of post-election engagement** with relevant institutions.

Figure 7: Country Ratings on Post- Election Engagement



Source: Analysed data from KII and FGDs

¹³ International IDEA (2023). *Global State of Democracy Report*

From the 21 countries assessed, only **five (Liberia, Somaliland, Somalia, Tanzania, Botswana)** scored between 9–10 under **Open/Free Dialogue Environments** which represents **24% of the assessed contexts**. These five countries exemplify environments where citizen election observers are not only welcomed but meaningfully engaged in post-election dialogue. The platforms for consultation are structured, permanent, and allow for reciprocal interaction between civil society and government institutions—particularly Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs).

- **Liberia** stands out for its structured and inclusive electoral governance system. The National Elections Commission (NEC) regularly incorporates inputs from observer groups such as the Election Coordinating Committee (ECC), whose technical reports and reform proposals are publicly acknowledged and discussed in parliamentary and regulatory spaces. Notably, the National Democratic Institute (NDI, 2021) cited Liberia's post-election debriefing mechanisms as a regional best practice in embedding observer feedback into reform agendas. The NEC has also co-hosted civil society roundtables with ECOWAS and the UNDP to facilitate post-election reviews.
- In **Botswana**, the tradition of inclusive stakeholder engagement is long established. The Independent Electoral Commission (IEC) holds regular post-election forums that include domestic observer networks, political parties, and academia. According to the Electoral Institute for Sustainable Democracy in Africa (EISA)¹⁴, Botswana's consultation process includes structured timelines for submissions, formal feedback loops, and cross-sector engagement. The country's stable political environment further enhances the impact of civil society feedback on electoral legislation and administrative improvements.
- **Somaliland** and **Somalia**, while operating in fragile security and institutional contexts, have benefited from internationally supported platforms that integrate civil society into electoral evaluation. In Somaliland, the Joint Election Observation Mission (JEOM) coordinated by Interpeace and local partners such as SONSAF, has led to the institutionalization of post-election reviews. These forums are recognized by both the National Electoral Commission (NEC) and political stakeholders, forming part of broader state-building processes¹⁵. In Somalia, post-election consultations are often facilitated by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Somalia (UNSOM) and the UNDP, enabling civil society to contribute to electoral frameworks even amidst complex federal transitions.
- **Tanzania** has established formal mechanisms for civil society input through the National Electoral Commission (NEC). Organizations such as the Tanzania

¹⁴ EISA (2020). *Botswana Electoral Assessment Reports*

¹⁵ Interpeace (2021). *Somaliland JEOM Final Report*

Civil Society Consortium for Election Observation (TACCEO) have participated in post-election assessments and dialogues, particularly following the 2015 and 2020 general elections. However, the quality of this engagement has fluctuated depending on the ruling administration. While the structure exists, the political receptivity to critique from civil society remains mixed, especially under restrictive legislation like the Media Services Act and Statistics Act.¹⁶

Key Characteristics

- **Institutionalized platforms** for regular dialogue (e.g., structured meetings, feedback schedules).
- **Inclusivity** of different observer networks, including marginalized and regional groups.
- **Recognition of observer recommendations** in public reform discourse or parliamentary discussions.
- **Donor facilitation** (e.g., Interpeace, UNDP, NDI) supporting sustainability and neutrality of platforms.

Countries such as **Ghana, Eswatini, South Africa, Ethiopia, and Zambia** find themselves under **Restricted Dialogue environments** with ratings of between 7-8 representing **24% of the assessed contexts**. These countries have relatively open civic engagement with EMBs, though the platforms for post-election dialogue are often episodic, elite-controlled, or reactive rather than institutionalized. In these environments, citizen observer organizations may be included in consultations, but the quality, frequency, and influence of their recommendations remain limited.

- **Ghana** has historically maintained one of the more stable democratic systems in West Africa, with regular elections and active civic participation. The Electoral Commission (EC) does engage civil society groups like the Coalition of Domestic Election Observers (CODEO) in post-election briefings and validation exercises. However, according to the EU Election Observation Mission¹⁷ and the Civic Forum Initiative (CFI), the EC is often perceived as resistant to critical recommendations. Post-election dialogues are not always formalized into ongoing reform processes, and the lack of a legal mandate for post-election review hinders implementation. Feedback loops remain largely one-directional and at the discretion of the EC.
- In **South Africa**, civil society groups such as MyVoteCounts, CASAC, and the Electoral Institute of South Africa (EISA) have historically influenced

¹⁶ TACCEO (2021). *Post-Election Analysis of Tanzania's Electoral Environment*

¹⁷ EU Election Observation Mission – Ghana Final Report (2020)

electoral reform debates. The Electoral Commission of South Africa (IEC) maintains open lines for observer registration and submissions. However, recent years have seen increased tension, particularly over issues such as campaign finance transparency and party list reforms. The 2021 amendment to the Electoral Act, prompted by a court ruling, saw limited public engagement, leading CSOs to criticize the process as top-down and insufficiently participatory (MyVoteCounts, 2022).

- **Ethiopia's National Election Board (NEBE)** has significantly improved its relationship with civil society since the 2019 institutional reform spearheaded by former human rights advocate Birtukan Mideksa. These reforms included open consultations on legal frameworks and cooperation with observers during the 2021 elections. However, ongoing conflicts in Tigray and other regions, coupled with periodic internet shutdowns and political volatility, continue to disrupt the institutionalization of post-election dialogues. According to the Carter Center¹⁸, while NEBE has made strides, its ability to facilitate national reform conversations remains constrained by Ethiopia's broader security landscape.
- In **Zambia**, civil society's access to post-election consultations has improved under recent administrations, especially following the peaceful transfer of power in 2021. Organizations such as the Christian Churches Monitoring Group (CCMG) have been engaged in feedback sessions with the Electoral Commission of Zambia (ECZ). However, the dialogue process remains informal, and uptake of observer recommendations varies depending on political context. Concerns about uneven participation and selective engagement persist, especially during constitutional review cycles¹⁹.
- **Eswatini** permits limited civil society engagement through government-run forums like the Elections and Boundaries Commission (EBC) stakeholder meetings. However, independent observers and human rights defenders report that these dialogues are often tokenistic and lack institutional follow-up. As noted by CIVICUS Monitor (2023) and Freedom House²⁰, state security concerns continue to frame election-related civic engagement as "political interference," undermining trust and legitimacy in consultation spaces.

Characteristics of Restricted Dialogue Spaces

- Engagement is **not legally mandated or recurring**.

¹⁸ Carter Center (2021). *Ethiopia Elections Report*

¹⁹ Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung Zambia (2022). *Civic Space and Electoral Reform*

²⁰ Freedom House (2023). *Freedom in the World Reports*

- Participation may be **selective**, with opposition-linked CSOs excluded.
- Observer input is often received **without commitment to reform**.
- Dialogue spaces may be convened only around elections, with **no permanent forums**.

Countries such as **Madagascar, Kenya, Nigeria, Cameroon and Chad** are those under **Obstructed Dialogue Environments** representing **24% of the assessed contexts**. These countries, scoring 5–6 on the civic space scale for post-election engagement, reflect superficial or inconsistent dialogue mechanisms between electoral management bodies (EMBs) and citizen observer organizations. While formal invitations or engagements may exist, these are frequently reactive, ad hoc, or symbolic, lacking accountability, feedback loops, or a genuine commitment to reform.

- **Kenya:** Although often cited as a regional leader in electoral innovation, Kenya's post-election dialogue landscape has remained highly politicized and episodic. Following the deeply contested 2017 presidential elections and subsequent nullification by the Supreme Court, observer groups such as ELOG (Election Observation Group) and KPTJ (Kenyans for Peace with Truth and Justice) were invited into consultations by the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission (IEBC). However, as noted in the Carter Center's 2022 Kenya Election Observation Report, these efforts lacked institutional permanence. Many observer recommendations—especially on electoral technology, party primaries, and disinformation—have not been integrated into legal or policy frameworks. The absence of a legally mandated post-election review process has contributed to inconsistencies in CSO engagement over multiple cycles (Carter Center, 2022).
- **Nigeria:** The Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) has periodically engaged civil society actors like Yiaga Africa, CLEEN Foundation, and the Transition Monitoring Group (TMG) in electoral roundtables and technical debriefs. However, the reform process in Nigeria is slow, opaque, and highly politicized. Key observer recommendations—such as reforms to the Electoral Act, electronic transmission of results, and campaign finance regulation—have faced political resistance or bureaucratic inertia, particularly when they threaten incumbent advantage. According to Chatham House (2023) and Yiaga Africa's 2023 post-election report, CSOs often find their recommendations acknowledged but not acted upon, limiting their influence on substantive electoral change.
- **Cameroon:** While the Elections Cameroon (ELECAM) commission formally invites observer organizations to debriefing meetings, there is no structured follow-up mechanism. Civil society leaders report that these forums are largely ceremonial and tend to occur under international donor pressure

rather than domestic initiative. According to the International Foundation for Electoral Systems (IFES) and Afrobarometer, ELECAM suffers from perceived lack of independence, and observer inputs are rarely reflected in legislative amendments or operational shifts. CSOs such as Redhac and Dynamique Citoyenne have criticized the exclusion of dissenting voices and lack of transparency in the decision-making process.

- **Madagascar:** The country maintains nominal spaces for civic dialogue on elections, especially during donor-funded electoral cycles. However, CSO involvement is largely dependent on international mediation, with few national platforms sustaining long-term reform dialogue. The 2018 elections saw limited engagement from domestic observers post-election, as reported by The Electoral Institute for Sustainable Democracy in Africa (EISA). Observer groups like KMF/CNOE noted that although they were permitted to observe and submit reports, their recommendations lacked traction with the Commission Électorale Nationale Indépendante (CENI) or Parliament. Madagascar's volatile political landscape and executive dominance over institutions further constrain sustained reform efforts.

Key Traits of Obstructed Dialogue Settings

- No legal obligation for EMBs to implement observer feedback.
- Consultations are infrequent or held under political pressure.
- Participation may be selective, symbolic, or lacking transparency.
- Recommendations are often acknowledged without resulting action.

Under **Repressed/Threatened dialogue Environments** are countries like **Uganda, Tunisia, Côte d'Ivoire, Zimbabwe** representing 19.0% of the assessed contexts. These four countries, each scoring between 3–4 on the civic dialogue index, represent environments where post-election engagement with citizen observers is highly constrained, politicized, or repressive. Civil society organizations (CSOs) face state-sanctioned limitations, selective invitations, or reprisals for attempting to influence electoral reform. Dialogue tends to be performative, lacking in transparency, and often excludes independent or critical voices.

- **Uganda** presents one of the most restrictive cases in Africa when it comes to post-election civic engagement. The Electoral Commission (EC) has repeatedly been accused of only engaging pro-government organizations, while sidelining or targeting independent observer groups such as the Uganda National NGO Forum (UNNGOF) and Chapter Four Uganda. During the 2021 general elections, at least 27 domestic election observers were arrested, and major NGOs involved in election monitoring had their licenses suspended or bank accounts frozen (Human Rights Watch, 2021; CIVICUS Monitor, 2023). Laws such as the NGO Act (2016) and the Public Order

Management Act are routinely invoked to criminalize civic activism. While some court petitions have challenged these moves, judicial protection has proven weak. The result is a post-election environment where engagement is both discouraged and dangerous.

- **Tunisia**, once considered a democratic outlier in North Africa following the 2011 Arab Spring, has witnessed a dramatic regression in civic space since 2021. President Kais Saied's consolidation of power, including suspending Parliament and dissolving the electoral commission (ISIE), has coincided with growing restrictions on civil society, especially organizations engaged in governance, anti-corruption, and elections (Freedom House, 2023). I-Watch, Tunisia's leading domestic observer and anti-corruption group, has faced judicial harassment, restrictions on foreign funding, and defamation by public officials. Observer groups are increasingly excluded from official consultations and delegitimized as foreign agents when advocating for reforms.
- **Zimbabwe** continues to operate in a climate of deep mistrust between the state and civil society. The Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) has a legal obligation to consult stakeholders, but these consultations have been described by observer coalitions such as ZESN (Zimbabwe Election Support Network) and ERC (Election Resource Centre) as tokenistic and exclusionary. The Patriot Act, passed in 2023, criminalizes any civic engagement deemed as "unpatriotic," including collaboration with international democracy partners (Amnesty International, 2023). NGOs involved in elections have reported surveillance, raids, deregistration threats, and public smear campaigns. In many cases, observers are blamed for election-related unrest, further eroding trust and disincentivizing open dialogue.
- In **Côte d'Ivoire**, civil society participation in electoral processes has diminished significantly since the 2020 presidential elections, which were marred by violence and boycotts. Although some observer organizations like POECI (Plateforme des Organisations de la Société Civile pour l'Observation des Élections en Côte d'Ivoire) remain active, they report that post-election recommendations are rarely acted upon and that the Independent Electoral Commission (CEI) operates with limited transparency or accountability. Tensions between the ruling elite and opposition-aligned CSOs have led to a general atmosphere of fear and self-censorship among observers (International Crisis Group, 2021).

Common Characteristics

- Selective engagement with politically affiliated or apolitical NGOs.
- Judicial and administrative harassment of independent observers.

- Tokenistic dialogue, with no intention to reform based on civil society input.
- Use of legislation to criminalize dissent and foreign-funded advocacy.
- State-controlled narratives that delegitimize civil society as “unpatriotic” or “foreign agents.”

South Sudan, and Republic of the Congo (Congo-Brazzaville) are countries under **Closed Dialogue Environments** which is 9.0% of the assessed contexts. These two countries, scoring 0–2 on the civic dialogue scale, represent severely restricted or non-existent environments for post-election consultation between citizen observers and government institutions. In these contexts, electoral engagement is either criminalized, politically stigmatized, or monopolized by state-controlled entities, rendering genuine dialogue virtually impossible.

- **South Sudan**, despite formally transitioning into independence in 2011, has yet to hold a national election since statehood. Although elections are scheduled for late 2024 under the Revitalized Peace Agreement (R-ARCSS), there is no existing precedent or legal framework for post-election dialogue between civil society and electoral bodies. Civil society actors—such as CEPO (Community Empowerment for Progress Organization)—have repeatedly called for inclusive consultation processes, but these efforts are often framed by the state as undermining peace or inciting dissent. According to the International Crisis Group (2023) and Amnesty International, civic actors involved in electoral governance or reform face harassment, surveillance, and arbitrary detention, especially those perceived as critical of government plans. The lack of an independent electoral commission (NEC) and militarized political culture further hinder any prospects for structured civic dialogue.
- In the **Republic of the Congo (Congo-Brazzaville)**, the post-election environment is tightly controlled by the ruling party, and civil society space is functionally closed. The Independent National Electoral Commission (CNEI) is widely regarded as lacking autonomy, with electoral processes consistently marred by allegations of fraud, suppression, and exclusion of independent monitors. Civil society groups that attempt to engage in electoral reform advocacy are often subjected to bureaucratic obstruction, license revocations, and in some cases, arrest (Freedom House, 2023; CIVICUS Monitor, 2022). Post-election forums—where they exist—serve more as state propaganda platforms than mechanisms for meaningful consultation. Organizations such as Observatoire Congolais des Droits de l’Homme (OCDH) have reported that attempts to provide independent post-election assessments have been met with state hostility and smear campaigns.

Key Indicators of a Closed Dialogue Environment

- No formal or legal platform for post-election dialogue.

- Repression of CSOs, including arrests, license cancellations, or forced closures.
- Complete dominance by ruling party in managing election outcomes and narratives.
- Civic engagement is equated with subversion, destabilization, or treason.
- International recommendations are either ignored or dismissed as foreign interference.

3.7.1 Recommendations to Strengthen Post-Election Dialogue Between Citizen Observers and Electoral Institutions in Africa.

1. Institutionalize Post-Election Dialogue Mechanisms

Embed permanent, legally mandated platforms for structured, inclusive dialogue between Electoral Management Bodies (EMBs) and accredited citizen observer organizations. These should include clear timelines, transparent agendas, and public documentation of discussions and agreed reforms.

2. Guarantee Inclusive and Non-Discriminatory Participation

Ensure that all accredited observer groups—including those critical of the government—have equal access to consultation forums. Mechanisms should prevent political gatekeeping, tokenism, or exclusion of marginalized voices such as youth, women, and rural-based observers.

3. Establish Feedback and Implementation Frameworks

Create formal processes for EMBs and relevant parliamentary committees to respond to observer recommendations, including progress tracking, public reporting, and incorporation into legislative or regulatory reforms.

4. Strengthen EMB Independence and Capacity

Enhance the autonomy, resources, and technical skills of EMBs to engage meaningfully with civil society without political interference. This includes building dedicated civic engagement units within EMBs to manage ongoing relations with observers.

5. Leverage Regional Standards and Peer Learning

Regional bodies such as the African Union, ECOWAS, EAC, and SADC should develop and enforce minimum standards for post-election civic dialogue. They can facilitate peer-learning exchanges where EMBs from more open environments mentor counterparts in restrictive contexts.

6. Protect Observers from Retaliation

Adopt and enforce legal safeguards that protect observers from harassment, deregistration, or criminalization for participating in post-election consultations or publishing critical findings. This aligns with the African Charter on Democracy, Elections, and Governance.

7. Integrate Dialogue into Electoral Cycles

Shift from ad hoc, election-only consultations to continuous engagement across the electoral cycle—covering voter registration, campaign regulation, election day procedures, and dispute resolution.

8. Promote Donor Support for Sustained Platforms

Encourage international and domestic donors to fund multi-year dialogue mechanisms, rather than one-off post-election events. This supports continuity, institutional memory, and trust-building between stakeholders.

3.8 Dimension 8 – Perception Towards Citizen Observers

This dimension assesses how citizen observers are perceived by four primary stakeholders: ruling parties, opposition parties, the media, and the general public. The perception significantly influences the operating environment, trustworthiness, and legitimacy of citizen observers. The analysis covers 21 African countries using a rating scale from 0 to 10:

- **9–10:** Open/Free – high public trust and institutional endorsement.
- **7–8:** Restricted – generally positive, though subject to limitations.
- **5–6:** Obstructed – mixed perception; often politicized or misunderstood.
- **3–4:** Repressed/Threatened – stigmatized, delegitimized.
- **0–2:** Closed – outright hostility or criminalization of observation.

Table 1: Rating Summary

Category	Countries	Count	Percentage
Open/Free (9–10)	Liberia, Somaliland, Somalia, Ghana, Botswana	5	23.8%
Restricted (7–8)	Ethiopia, Eswatini, South Africa, Tanzania	4	19.0%
Obstructed (5–6)	Congo-Brazzaville, Uganda, Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Chad, Côte d'Ivoire	7	33.3%

Repressed (3–4)	Tunisia, Cameroon, Madagascar, Zimbabwe	4	19.0%
Closed (0–2)	South Sudan	1	4.8%

Open/Free Perception Environments (23.8%)

Countries: Liberia, Somaliland, Somalia, Ghana, Botswana

Percentage of Sample: 23.8% (5 out of 21 countries)

These countries provide strong enabling environments for citizen election observers, where public institutions, political stakeholders, and the media recognize observer groups as credible contributors to democratic processes. Observation is not merely tolerated but valued—often resulting in structured collaboration, institutional engagement, and public trust.

Liberia is widely regarded as a model for observer-government collaboration in post-conflict contexts. The Election Coordinating Committee (ECC)—a coalition of local civil society organizations—plays an integral role in Liberia’s electoral processes.

The National Elections Commission (NEC) regularly engages ECC before, during, and after elections, and its findings are widely cited in public debates and parliamentary hearings. ECC’s **neutrality, technical depth**, and commitment to peaceful elections have earned it broad credibility from both ruling and opposition parties²¹.

Botswana offers a mature democratic environment characterized by respect for civic voices and rule of law. Observer organizations—often coordinated by the Electoral Commission of Botswana (IEC) and civil society groups like the Botswana Council of Non-Governmental Organisations (BOCONGO)—participate in long-standing frameworks for electoral monitoring.

Reports from EISA (2020) describe the constructive relationship between electoral bodies and CSOs, which extends to joint voter education, policy consultations, and post-election dialogue. The general public is also well-informed about the role of observers, who are regularly featured in media programming.

In Ghana, the Coalition of Domestic Election Observers (CODEO) enjoys strong legitimacy and public trust. CODEO is seen as a neutral and professional body, trusted by both the ruling and opposition parties. During the 2020 elections, EU Election Observation Mission (EU EOM, 2020) highlighted CODEO’s real-time parallel vote tabulation (PVT) as a credible check on the official results. The group’s

²¹ NDI (2021). *Liberia Election Observation Mission Report*

broad media visibility and meticulous reporting have contributed to widespread public appreciation of its role in protecting electoral integrity and democracy.

In Somalia and Somaliland, despite persistent security and governance challenges, Somalia and Somaliland have witnessed a growing appreciation for citizen observers, primarily due to donor-funded electoral assistance and civic education campaigns.

In Somaliland, the **Somaliland Non-State Actors Forum (SONSAF)** has been instrumental in election observation, working closely with the **National Electoral Commission (NEC)** and international partners.

In Somalia, Interpeace²² reports that Joint Election Observation Missions (JEOMs) composed of domestic and international partners have **boosted the credibility** of observation and improved media framing of observer roles.

While the security context remains volatile, citizen observers are increasingly seen as neutral third parties essential to peacebuilding and democratic transition.

Common Features of Open/Free Perception Environments:

- Observers enjoy institutional recognition from electoral commissions.
- Media visibility and public education reinforce observer legitimacy.
- Political elites view observers as partners rather than adversaries.
- Observer recommendations inform policy reforms and electoral improvements.

Restricted Perception Environments (19.0%)

Countries: Ethiopia, Eswatini, South Africa, Tanzania

Percentage of Sample: 19.0% (4 out of 21 countries)

These countries exhibit generally favorable but conditional perceptions of citizen election observers. While there is legal space for observation and public acknowledgment of its value, trust remains fragile, and observers must navigate narratives of suspicion—especially when their findings are critical of the status quo. Engagement with observers is tolerated, but rarely fully embraced by political elites or uniformly supported by the media.

South Africa maintains a strong tradition of citizen observation through organizations like My Vote Counts (MVC) and Electoral Institute for Sustainable

²² Interpeace (2021). *Somaliland and Somalia Election Observation Lessons Learned*

Democracy in Africa (EISA). These groups are widely respected for contributing to political accountability and electoral transparency. However, civil society involvement in politically sensitive issues—particularly campaign finance reform and party transparency—has drawn resistance from political elites, especially the ruling African National Congress (ANC). According to My Vote Counts (2022), calls for increased disclosure of party donors were met with institutional pushback and media framing that painted observers as overreaching. Still, observers remain central actors in the electoral process and enjoy substantial public credibility.

In Ethiopia, Citizen observers gained significant visibility during the June 2021 general elections, amid an ongoing civil conflict in the Tigray region. According to the African Union Election Observation Mission (2021) and Ethiopian Civil Society Organizations Council, observers played a vital role in fostering transparency under difficult conditions.

However, state-aligned narratives often questioned the neutrality of CSOs operating in conflict-affected regions, labeling them as politically motivated or Western-backed. Observers also faced access limitations in conflict zones, and public perception remains influenced by regional and ethnic divides, which can complicate the perceived legitimacy of election monitors.

In **Eswatini**, civil society observers such as the Coordinating Assembly of NGOs (CANGO) have engaged in election monitoring, especially during the country's tinkhundla (non-party) electoral system processes.

While the state has allowed some observer presence, high political centralization under the monarchy fosters a climate in which observers are sometimes seen as disruptors rather than partners. Independent findings are rarely acted upon, and observer criticism of the process can provoke media or official rebuke. Nonetheless, space exists for civic engagement—albeit with caution.

Tanzania has oscillated between openness and restriction in recent years. Under President Samia Suluhu Hassan, there has been a slight improvement in civic freedoms compared to the repression seen under President Magufuli (CIVICUS, 2023).

While domestic observer groups like Tanzania Elections Watch are allowed to monitor elections, their findings are often received with suspicion by ruling party affiliates. Observers who raise concerns about media bias or vote counting transparency may be branded as politically influenced. Public awareness of their role remains moderate, but observer input is often overlooked in formal post-election discussions.

Common Themes in Restricted Environments:

- Observers are allowed legal space but must navigate elite suspicion.
- Political leaders tolerate monitoring but resist critical recommendations.
- Public support exists, but media framing can still stigmatize observers.

- Engagement is conditional: tolerated when findings align with official narratives, challenged when they don't.

Obstructed Perception Environments (33.3%)

Countries: Congo-Brazzaville, Uganda, Zambia, Nigeria, Kenya, Chad, Côte d'Ivoire
Percentage of Sample: 33.3% (7 out of 21 countries)

In these contexts, citizen observers operate in ambiguous and often politicized spaces. While not outright banned, their legitimacy is frequently contested by ruling authorities or political elites. Observers may be publicly tolerated but are privately mistrusted, resulting in selective access, limited visibility, and public skepticism about their neutrality.

Kenya presents a complex dynamic: it has one of the most developed domestic observation coalitions on the continent—Election Observation Group (ELOG)—yet it also grapples with elite-driven narratives that question the group's neutrality, particularly during contested elections.

During the 2022 elections, ELOG and civil society actors raised concerns over the slow and fragmented transmission of polling station results. While this contributed to transparency, it also led to accusations of political bias from supporters of the ruling coalition (Carter Center, 2022). Media outlets occasionally mirror these divisions, amplifying distrust and undermining public confidence in observers' neutrality—even when findings are evidence-based.

In **Uganda**, the ruling regime under President Museveni views independent observation as a political threat. During the 2021 elections, over two dozen domestic observers were arrested and prominent civil society organizations had their licenses revoked or suspended (Human Rights Watch, 2021). State-run media outlets consistently portray domestic observers as foreign-influenced destabilizers, fostering hostility in public perception. While some segments of the public appreciate civic monitoring, the dominant narrative fueled by authorities has succeeded in eroding broad-based trust in independent election oversight.

Nigeria offers formal space for election observation, with the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) accrediting local and international groups. However, implementation and reception of observer findings remain politicized. Civic groups like Yiaga Africa have gained credibility for real-time Parallel Vote Tabulation (PVT), but their reports are often dismissed or downplayed by political elites, especially when they highlight irregularities that might question electoral outcomes²³.

Insecurity, partisan polarization, and media disinformation campaigns further **undermine public trust** in observer independence.

²³ Yiaga Africa (2023). *Nigeria Elections PVT Statement and Reaction*

Côte d'Ivoire has maintained a tenuous relationship with civil society observers. While legal space exists for observation, political discourse is highly polarized, especially following the 2020 controversial re-election of President Alassane Ouattara. Observer findings are selectively acknowledged, and criticisms from CSOs are frequently politicized, undermining their broader credibility²⁴.

Observers also report limited access to state media and difficulties in disseminating their findings to the wider public, reducing their effectiveness in shaping voter trust.

Zambia's observer ecosystem has traditionally been vibrant, but prior to the 2021 elections, observers reported heightened state surveillance and public skepticism fueled by pro-government media (Freedom House, 2021). While the situation has improved under the current administration, remnants of mistrust remain, particularly from political elites wary of critiques.

In **Chad and Congo-Brazzaville**, both provide nominal access to electoral processes for civil society but operate within heavily securitized environments. Government-aligned narratives dominate public discourse, with citizen observers framed as “agents of foreign interference” when their findings challenge official narratives. Media coverage of observation work is either muted or deliberately dismissive, limiting opportunities for observers to engage the public and build legitimacy through open reporting.

Common Challenges in Obstructed Perception Environments:

- State-aligned media undermining observer neutrality
- Public distrust due to polarized political contexts
- Limited access to platforms for disseminating findings
- Official tolerance masking deep institutional suspicion

Repressed/Threatened Perception Environments (19.0%)

Countries: Tunisia, Cameroon, Madagascar, Zimbabwe

Percentage of Sample: 19.0% (4 out of 21 countries)

In these countries, citizen election observers are often regarded with deep suspicion by political elites, ruling regimes, and in some cases the public. These perceptions reflect broader patterns of shrinking civic space, where civil society organizations (CSOs) are systematically delegitimized, surveilled, or repressed, especially around electoral periods.

²⁴ NDI (2020). *Côte d'Ivoire Pre-Election Assessment Mission Report*

In **Zimbabwe**, citizen observer groups such as the Zimbabwe Election Support Network (ZESN) and Election Resource Centre (ERC) have long been accused by state actors of political bias. During the 2018 and 2023 elections, state-controlled media frequently launched coordinated smear campaigns against domestic observers, framing them as aligned with opposition parties or foreign interests²⁵ (Amnesty International, 2023; The Conversation, 2023). These attacks have contributed to polarized public perceptions, where observers are seen not as neutral monitors, but as partisan actors²⁶.

Observers have also faced restrictions on accreditation, harassment at polling stations, and post-election raids. The ruling party, ZANU-PF, has historically resisted reforms suggested by civic actors, further deepening antagonism.

Tunisia, once considered a beacon of democratic progress in the Arab world, has witnessed a rapid and systematic erosion of civic space, particularly for election observers. The perception of citizen observers has deteriorated sharply under President Kais Saied's administration, especially following his 2021 power consolidation and the 2022 restructuring of the electoral commission.

As of October 2024, Human Rights Watch (HRW) reported that authorities have intensified their crackdown on civil society organizations in the lead-up to national elections. The Independent High Authority for Elections (ISIE)—now under the de facto control of the executive—arbitrarily denied accreditation to two of the country's most prominent observer groups: I Watch and Mourakiboun. In a statement issued on September 9, the commission claimed the denial was due to “suspicious foreign funding from countries with which Tunisia does not have diplomatic relations.” It referred the matter for criminal investigation, in a move widely interpreted as an effort to delegitimize and intimidate domestic observers.

This action reflects a broader trend of shrinking space for dissent and growing state hostility toward independent electoral scrutiny. The government's increasing use of foreign funding accusations as political tool echoes tactics seen in more authoritarian contexts, where legal justifications are used to suppress organizations critical of state conduct.

Furthermore, the denial of accreditation is not only an administrative barrier—it sends a chilling message to other civic actors and fosters a climate of fear, leading to self-censorship and withdrawal from the electoral process. The media environment has also become more polarized, with limited room for critical reporting on electoral transparency or civic engagement.

The combined effect is a deep delegitimization of citizen observers in the public eye, where their role is no longer seen as contributing to electoral integrity but as

²⁵ Amnesty International (2023). *Zimbabwe: Election observers attacked, silenced*

²⁶ The Conversation (2023). *Why Zimbabwe's elections keep failing the credibility test*

threatening national sovereignty or foreign-influenced. This transformation in perception has severely compromised the ability of Tunisian observers to operate freely, independently, and credibly.

Cameroon presents a context of institutional hostility and widespread public apathy toward observers. Electoral processes are tightly controlled by the ruling Cameroon People's Democratic Movement (CPDM), and groups like Un Monde Avenir or Transparency International-Cameroon report routine intimidation, state surveillance, and limitations on observer access.

Observers are often **excluded from national debates** on electoral reform, and public messaging tends to delegitimize non-government-affiliated actors. Journalistic coverage of observation efforts is minimal or framed negatively, especially in state-run outlets.

In **Madagascar**, while civil society remains active, the space for electoral observers is **constrained by state suspicion and low public awareness**. Organizations like **Safidy** and the **National Observation Platform** have participated in election monitoring, but **state institutions have been slow to act on observer recommendations**, especially when politically sensitive.

The **media offers limited visibility** to observer roles, and political actors frequently challenge their neutrality, particularly during contentious election cycles (IFES, 2019). Observers also face logistical and legal hurdles that further limit their perceived relevance.

Key Trends Across These Countries

- State-controlled narratives equate observers with political interference or opposition.
- Legal instruments (NGO laws, media restrictions) are weaponized to curtail observer influence.
- Media and elite framing erode public trust in observers, often portraying them as part of a foreign or anti-national agenda.
- Recommendations from CSOs are ignored, leading to disillusionment about their effectiveness.

Closed Perception Environment (4.8%)

Country: South Sudan

In South Sudan, the public perception and political attitude toward citizen observers are virtually nonexistent or overtly hostile. The country scores at the lowest end (0–2) on the civic perception scale due to widespread repression and the absence of institutional or public support for election monitoring.

Despite being a signatory to the Revitalized Agreement on the Resolution of the Conflict in the Republic of South Sudan (R-ARCSS), which calls for democratic

elections and civic participation, the transitional government has not facilitated any formal role for citizen observers in election preparation or democratic accountability. According to Amnesty International²⁷ and CIVICUS Monitor²⁸, civil society actors, including journalists and grassroots organizations, are routinely targeted by the National Security Service (NSS) through surveillance, harassment, arbitrary arrests, and enforced disappearances.

The general public is largely unaware of the function or value of citizen observers, in part due to the government's tight control over information and civic education, and in part due to the protracted conflict that has crowded out democratic discourse. Electoral observers, where they exist, operate through international institutions like the UN Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS) rather than through nationally recognized or community-based frameworks.

Additionally, civil society organizations attempting to organize around democratic participation or electoral transparency are often branded as anti-government or foreign agents, particularly if they receive external funding or question state narratives. There is no legal infrastructure or procedural protection for observer groups, and no history of inclusive dialogue with electoral institutions—primarily because a functional and independent electoral commission has yet to be established.²⁹

Notable Barriers:

- Lack of legal recognition or accreditation mechanisms for domestic observers.
- Public confusion between partisan activism and independent election observation.
- State propaganda that equates civic oversight with foreign intervention or subversion.
- Security threats: Numerous CSOs report direct targeting by the NSS and affiliated militias.

South Sudan represents one of the most closed and hostile environments for citizen election observers on the African continent. The complete absence of state or societal recognition of observation as a legitimate democratic function severely undermines electoral transparency, civic participation, and public accountability. Substantial reforms are required to create even the basic conditions for safe, recognized, and effective citizen observation in upcoming elections, currently tentatively scheduled for 2024.

²⁷ Amnesty International (2023). *South Sudan: Rampant State Repression Endangers Civil Society*

²⁸ CIVICUS Monitor (2023). *South Sudan Civic Space Rating – Closed*

²⁹ Human Rights Watch (2022). *South Sudan: Transition Undermined by Threats to Civic Space*

Challenges to Public Recognition of Citizen Observers

- Media distortion and framing of observers as biased or politically affiliated.
- Low civic literacy on the role and function of observers in electoral processes.
- Lack of state endorsement, limiting access to information and undermining legitimacy.
- Securitization of observation, especially during political transitions or conflict.

3.8.1 Recommendations for Strengthening public recognition and legitimacy of Citizen Election Observers in Africa

1. Strategic Public Awareness Campaigns

- Launch nationwide civic education programs—jointly run by observer coalitions, EMBs, and trusted community leaders—to explain the role, methodology, and neutrality of citizen observers.
- Use multiple media formats (radio, TV debates, social media, community theater) to make observation more relatable to citizens beyond urban centers.

2. Proactive Media Engagement

- Build long-term partnerships with independent and community media outlets to ensure balanced coverage of observation findings.
- Develop “media toolkits” for journalists to accurately report on observer mandates and avoid partisan framing.
- Train observer spokespeople in strategic communications to counter misinformation quickly.

3. Neutrality Assurance Mechanisms

- Adopt and publicize strict internal codes of conduct, peer-review protocols, and transparency in funding sources to strengthen public trust.
- In politically polarized contexts, involve respected professional associations (lawyers’ guilds, academia, religious councils) as co-signatories to observer reports.

4. Inclusive and Diversified Observer Coalitions

- Ensure observer networks reflect the country's ethnic, linguistic, gender, and regional diversity to counter perceptions of bias.
- Involve youth, persons with disabilities, and marginalized groups in observation missions to expand legitimacy across demographic lines.

5. Feedback Loops and Public Accountability

- Hold public debriefs in all regions where observers are deployed, explaining findings in accessible language.
- Track and publish government or EMB responses to recommendations to demonstrate impact and accountability.

6. Countering State-Led Disinformation

- Establish rapid response teams to monitor and debunk false narratives about observers, using verified data and neutral messengers.
- Coordinate with fact-checking organizations and regional networks to share counter-messaging strategies.

7. Regional and Continental Endorsement

- Secure formal recognition of domestic observers through African Union, ECOWAS, EAC, and SADC communiqués, framing them as essential democratic actors.
- Leverage peer recognition by linking national observer coalitions to continental platforms like the African Election Observers Network (AfEONet).

8. Donor Support for Perception-Shaping Activities

- Encourage donors to fund not only observation logistics but also long-term trust-building activities, including community dialogues, post-election follow-ups, and media literacy programs.
- Build local philanthropic engagement to avoid the perception of sole dependence on foreign funding.

9. Conflict-Sensitive Messaging in Fragile States

- In conflict or post-conflict settings, frame observation as a peacebuilding and trust-rebuilding activity, avoiding political terminology that could trigger suspicion.
- Use joint domestic-international missions strategically to provide credibility cover in volatile environments.

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